



Mutual Benefits

opening offer

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Contents

1. Chapter 1
2. Chapter 2
3. Chapter 3
4. Chapter 4
5. Chapter 5
6. Chapter 6
7. Chapter 7
8. Chapter 8
9. Chapter 9
10. Chapter 10

Also by

Chapter One

As soon as the elevator doors closed, Vanessa stole a sideways glance in the mirror. She tried to do it without Ryan noticing, but Ryan always noticed. Her lips soured slightly at what she saw in her reflection.

She really had no reason to be anything but pleased with herself. Vanessa was in her mid-forties, but no one had any reason to suspect her age based on her appearance alone. She had always been uptight about fitness, so she had muscle tone without being bulky, a slender waist that looked younger than most of her forty-ish counterparts, and the kind of face that didn't necessarily look youthful, but was aging extraordinarily well. Ryan would say she looked better now that she was older, and he wouldn't have been alone. Combined with Vanessa's very good sense of style, and her thick, long hair, she looked *hot*.

Ryan once made the mistake of telling her she looked hot in a sexy, older woman way, but that hadn't gone over well with her. Like a lot of things that Ryan viewed as compliments, Vanessa seemed to have taken it the wrong way. But she did look "older-woman hot," even if that was a thought he'd keep to himself from now on. Maybe it was her actual appearance, maybe it

was the underlying confidence. Whatever it was, she was far more appealing to him (and a lot of men) at her current age than when she was younger.

"You look great," he said, grinning as subtly as possible at the stainless steel of the elevator doors. Vanessa fidgeted and let out a small sigh. He was sure she rolled her eyes - it annoyed her a little when she got caught checking herself out like that.

Then she openly turned her torso toward the mirror and placed a hand on her belly, shaking her hair out as she stood up straight. Vanessa's waist was slim but she couldn't shake a small pouch that in Ryan's opinion was attractive as hell.

"Are you *sure* this is an appropriate outfit for this thing?" She moved her shoulders and brushed her hair back over her shoulder. "It just seems so... casual."

Ryan laughed as the elevator slowed its ascent, arriving at their designated floor. Already, the music from the cocktail party could be heard, filtering through the roof and then through the doors. "Casual," he said, in a voice he used to mock his younger coworkers, "is the tone at Nimbus Innovations." He punched the "Door close" button to delay their exit and turned toward his wife. "We are casual, innovative, and very attractive at Nimbus. You'll fit right in."

He was happy that she smiled and tipped her head sarcastically. "I'm not very innovative. Maybe I should go home."

"You only need two out of three," he quipped. Their hands brushed against each other as the doors began to open, and they clasped them briefly. This kind of shared jokiness was the one thing Ryan loved most about their marriage: in the end, it was them against the world.

"Good luck, Mr. Cole," she said, facing forward and grinning.

"Same to you, Mrs. Cole."

She grinned. "Oh, you can just call me Vanessa."

They were smiling as the music enveloped them, and the ambiance of the lavish party poured into the elevator and swept them out into Nimbus Innovation's umpteenth event, the name of which they had both forgotten. Vanessa, Ryan knew, would probably have preferred to be at home on her treadmill doing a workout and watching a TV show in yoga pants. So it was nice of her to put her game face on.

They were standing on an elevated platform, steps descending to an open area with high ceilings. Almost everything was made of glass or polished concrete with thick timber embedded in it. Projections of colorful, shape-changing blobs morphed on the walls, and people clustered in groups around what looked like food stations. Vanessa knew from experience that these were going to dispense foam food or another culinary innovation that she probably wouldn't like much.

Vanessa had been scanning the room, looking for a place to squeeze herself comfortably away and not get noticed. In that short time, a petite redhead with bouncing curls and a flawlessly fresh face had appeared in front of them. "Ryan," she said breathlessly.

She gave no indication of even noticing that Vanessa was there, and slipped a hand around Ryan's elbow. As she did this, she turned so that her back ended up basically cutting Vanessa off.

"So glad you're here, we need you down there with MacAllen, the insurance people? They're..." she laughed, finally glancing over her shoulder and giving the tiniest bit of recognition to Vanessa, "old, if you know what I mean."

Vanessa raised her right hand and curled her fingers in a little wave while winking at her husband. "Byeeee," she said.

Ryan shrugged apologetically. Vanessa didn't need to say anything aloud for him to know that he thought of Chloe as a little bitch, and it was things like this that made her think so.

"Oh, hey, hi, um... Mrs. Cole," Chloe said, as if reading Ryan's thoughts and being prompted to behave better. He could see that this last-minute nod to Vanessa's presence did not go over well with his wife.

It *was* Vanessa's opinion that she said it like a little bitch, and Chloe had no reason not to remember her first name. It irked Vanessa: Chloe was pretty, in her early twenties, and openly flirted with her husband all the time.

But she would be damned if she was going to let on that it bothered her. Vanessa smiled at Chloe like she was a kindergartner. "Oh, hi there Chloe. Don't you look nice this evening?" She might as well have asked her if she tied her own shoes, but because she didn't actually say that, Chloe had to eat it.

"I'll find you," Ryan mouthed over Chloe's head, as Chloe pulled him away and down the platform.

Vanessa could tell herself she didn't care about these twenty-something brats who worked at Nimbus, but if she had to be honest with herself, she at least wanted to blend in with them. Her eyes went around the room, focusing on each of the women. Then she scanned her own reflection in some of the mirrored walls scattered throughout the room.

She was wearing expensive, trendy jeans that a saleswoman had assured her were "hot," and "cool" enough to wear to this event. They fit snugly on her firm, slender thighs, and she had brown suede boots that came up to her

knees pulled over them. They were strategically ripped, which Vanessa found childish. She scowled at the "fashionable" tears, but tried to put them out of her mind.

A cream-colored blouse that was uncomfortably revealing of her midriff through the airy fabric cut low and showed off just enough of her cleavage, and a powder blue jacket that looked like cracked paint that gave way to an amber-colored base beneath it.

Her hair, a light brown with caramel highlights, at least looked amazing and she could be sure of that: it always did. She had been blessed with hair that "haired," as the young kids would say. She looked good, she decided. But she didn't look like these younger girls, whose wardrobes appeared to have been pulled out from under couch cushions and hastily arranged on their lithe, youthful bodies, without a care in the world. Vanessa, on the other hand, matched too well. She silently prayed she didn't somehow look matronly.

She headed for some food-foam, feeling a little self-conscious, and decided to have a drink. Drinking an openly alcoholic beverage at these events usually invited someone nearby to launch into a long story about how they *didn't* drink, and Vanessa kind of enjoyed being thought of as old-school cool – with her one glass of Merlot. Who was she to let on that one glass of Merlot was an indulgence she'd pay for with two lost hours of sleep?

She stationed herself by a food station where she felt like she could be out of the way, ordered a wine from a person who looked like a caterer, and pretended to be interested in the food being made there. She used this spectacle to search for Ryan and the bouncy, GenZ Chloe without having to look like a stalker.

It wasn't that she didn't trust Ryan. It *was* that she didn't trust Chloe, who was fond of openly flirting with him and did not seem to have any boundaries about it. In fact, most of these younger kids - and they did seem like children to her - had openly polyamorous relationships that were too difficult for Vanessa to understand. So they probably didn't think anything of throwing themselves at a married man. Chloe probably didn't even expect Vanessa to care.

Chloe was still touching Ryan, she noted. She had her hand around his bicep and she was bouncy next to him, her red curls shaking and gleaming, like a model for an ad for LoveUrCurls. Luckily, Chloe was right in a sight line directly over the top of whatever the "curator" of this particular food station was preparing, so Vanessa could look at Chloe as long as she liked without appearing to be psychotic.

"The food seems to be making you angry," a male voice said next to her. She had her wine at her lips and was taken by surprise, so she pressed her lips together while doing something else entirely with her hand, and almost poured wine all over her face.

She salvaged the scene just in the nick of time, but she knew it looked awkward.

She turned toward the source of the voice.

For a moment - a very, very brief one - she was caught so off-guard that she felt like she was in free-fall. It was Jasper Cooper, in the flesh, and she knew this because she'd seen pictures of him on the company website and her eyes had lingered on Jasper's face longer than she'd have cared to tell her husband.

Jasper was young: much younger than Ryan, much too young to be Ryan's boss - yet he was. His jaw was square and his eyes intensely green and

intelligent. A mop of deliberately mussed black hair sat atop his handsomely cocky face, on which mixed-race features played out *very pleasingly*.

He was also very tall. Very fit. His torso was long and smoothly pressed against an expensive t-shirt. He was wearing a jacket over this, and very expensive jeans. Something about the air of him made Vanessa think of Red Bull events. He was looking at her very intently. Very brazenly.

God, she thought. *What a dick he must be*.

Her lips curled into a smile and she left the wine glass near her mouth, turning it with her fingers as she grinned mysteriously. What had he even said to her? *Food, food, focus on the food*. "I'm just trying to figure it out."

"Are you," he said. This was a statement, not a sentence. It was unmistakable that he did not believe her. His eyes remained on hers for a moment that gave her an uncomfortable, palpable flutter in her chest, and then he very brazenly shifted his entire body, leaning slightly toward her and crooking his head. "It looks to me like you're looking at Chloe. And your husband. And trying to figure out what's going on there."

Vanessa decided to take a long, deliberate sip of her wine and say nothing to that at all. Her assessment of Jasper as a jerk seemed to have been correct. It was also ringing like an alarm bell in her head: he knew who she was. He knew who she was married to.

She had no idea what to make of *that*.

"I wouldn't worry," he said, to her silence. He was smiling. Smugly. So assured of himself.

It was hard not to get annoyed by this. Vanessa raised her eyebrows and did her best to smile. How very thoughtful of this man who was fifteen years younger than her. "Oh, good," she said sarcastically.

He picked up a plate from the food station and placed an unfamiliar utensil on it as he handed it to her. She took it, because there wasn't much else she could do besides shove it back at him, and he took her wine from her other hand in one smooth movement.

She was just getting ready to say something snarky about this and shoo him away, when he stunned her with: "Chloe is attractive. But the best-looking woman in this room is you. By far."

Vanessa had no idea what to say. Her mouth fell open in stages, and she tried to stop it, but failed. "I... what?" she stammered. Then she blew air through her nose and laughed lightly, shaking her head. Jasper was now standing, confidently gazing down at her, with a plate of food in his hand that he was picking at with the utensil. Another confident expression - not quite a smile - was spread across his face and lighting up his eyes.

He was pleased with himself for having made her stammer.

She was furious with herself that he had.

Vanessa unfolded her wrist so that the plate extended toward him like she was about to throw a Frisbee. "I didn't really want this," she told him. When he just grinned back at her - *so cocky*, she thought - he just kept grinning and tasting the food from his own plate.

What a dick, she thought. But Vanessa was old enough to know that she, like any other woman, found this level of confidence exhilarating and attractive. Her mind scattered: it was best to shut this - whatever it was - down. ASAP. Her eyes fell on his plate of food.

She placed her plate on top of his, smashing the remainder of his foam. It was a petulant move and it clearly stunned *him*. Then she picked up her wine glass from where he had set it and gave her hair a triumphant shake,

basking in the look of confusion that traveled briefly through his features, the air now turbulent in his nose, a stunned amusement.

He recovered, however, very quickly. After looking at his smashed food in surprise, a smile spread on his lips and he looked back up at her, grinning arrogantly.

"This is what I'm talking about," Jasper said, pointing his strange utensil at her. "This is what makes you so much more attractive."

He was full-on, hands-down, no-mistake flirting with her.

Ryan's *boss*.

Jasper. Who was like twenty-four years old. He turned the foam lingering on his utensil upside down and closed his lips around it. This was unmistakably sexual, or at least alluding to something sexual, and Vanessa could have kicked herself because it stirred something pleasantly sexual inside her own abdomen.

Way down there.

"You know what you want," Jasper said, his eyes shifting to the remaining foam on his utensil, which he licked off with definite sexual connotations. "Most of these girls are hot. Because they're young. But they lack what you have."

Vanessa lost it. She tipped her head back and laughed, a little relieved. This Jasper kid was clearly one of those flirt-with-everything types, probably also a fuck-it-if-it-moves types. "What's that?" she said, preparing to take another sip of wine. "Crow's feet and half a full pension stashed away somewhere?"

She expected this to make Jasper laugh and crack a joke at her expense. That would diffuse the whole weird situation.

Instead he got quite serious. His eyes went to his plate and the foam on it, then back to her as he brought it to his mouth. "You don't have either of those things," he said, and closed his lips - his sensual, full lips - around the utensil, which now seemed to be a funky spork, if she had to guess.

Vanessa was not usually dumbstruck, but now she was. She had no idea what to say to that, and her mind had gone absolutely blank. She sipped her wine, nodding slowly like she was in on some kind of joke.

Was she crazy, or was her husband's boss openly, actually, flirting with her? She had to be misinterpreting things.

This generation, she thought.

It really didn't help that Jasper was physically tempting. He was cocky, self-assured, arrogant... all things that she usually felt repulsed by, especially in a younger man. It didn't help that she wasn't feeling so much revulsion toward him as... mild interest.

There was an awkward silence while Jasper stood there, staring at her openly, and she sipped her wine without saying anything.

"Don't you have, uh... important things to do? Here?" she asked, unable to take it anymore.

He set the plates down on the tray of a passing waiter, whose first reaction was to be annoyed. When the waiter saw who it was, he became deferential and stacked the plates carefully before giving Jasper a nod. "Oh you mean like, because I'm the boss?" he asked.

His tone was playful and also not. His green eyes penetrated hers. It was all she could do to stare back at him without somehow backing down; he was burning through her skin and making her feel like sweat was gathering underneath it.

Boiling.

A shiver escaped from this ecosystem and ran along her arms and shoulder blades; she was infinitely grateful to be wearing a jacket.

"I know who you are, Jasper Cooper," she said. Her own tone surprised her. It was half-flirtatious.

"And I know who you are, Vanessa Cole."

She raised her eyebrows. "Well. Then you know I'm married."

This, she figured, should do it. It was a curt tone, one meant to cut him down to size. He would most likely make some joke about how he wasn't really flirting, and she would be mildly embarrassed, and he would go on his way.

Instead, he lifted a drink from the table and pointed a finger at her. He didn't make a move to leave, and he didn't appear flustered. "That," he said.

She waited. She shrugged when he didn't continue.

"That's what you have," he said. "That they don't."

She let out a laugh. "That I'm married?" Okay, so this was the kind of guy he was.

He was already shaking his head. "No, nah, no. *That.*" He leaned in toward her. "You're bossy. Authoritative. You don't happen to have any glasses you could lower down your nose, do you?"

"Oh my God," Vanessa said, laughing as she shook her head.

Jasper Cooper stood up straight and put his hands in his pockets. Then he took a step closer to her. It was too close, by any measurement from any member of any generation, to not be taken as a "move." Vanessa's breath caught in her throat. She didn't want it to, she didn't like anything that was happening to her, if she was being honest. It felt like a can of slithering, cold snakes had been unleashed in her abdomen... some heading south, some crawling beneath her skin to her limbs, some cool inside her chest.

He leaned again. His voice was very low, and the music was very loud.

"Men like me like women like you," he said. "Some of us pay a lot of money for a woman like you to tell us what to do."

She froze. In all her life she'd never had a man approach her with this much confidence.

This much well-placed confidence, anyway.

"I don't really do that kind of thing," she informed him. "The dominatrix thing, that is."

The words were out of her mouth before she even registered them in her conscious mind, and she was as stunned as if someone else had used her head as a puppet. That was over the line. It almost sounded... mutually flirtatious.

It had also given her a rush. Blood was surging up to her skin, heat traveling all over her neck and her cheeks, tiny hairs becoming erect all over the place. Her heart was beating faster.

Jasper was looking at her calmly. His lips were still turned up in a smile, and it was the kind of smile that was obviously not frequent for him. He put his thumb into his mouth and closed his lips around the very tip of it, presumably to suck something from it. "Me either."

A moment of nuclear heat shimmered in the air between them. Vanessa did not breathe. Jasper's eyes glimmered.

He was grinning as he turned around, hands in pockets, and walked away casually. Her hand was halfway to her mouth with her drink. A cool paralysis was holding her there, face frozen in an expression that was as neutral as she could make it, while behind her forehead, thoughts scrambled and snakes of icy heat shot out in all directions in her body.

Did he just -?

She couldn't even be sure he had just said what he just said.

Surely he didn't.

She brought the drink to her lips and tried to remain calm and unaffected as her heart beat quickly with an unknown sensation.

Jasper looked back over his shoulder once he arrived at the edge of a cluster of people and began to shake hands. His back was muscular; she could tell, even through the jacket.

His green eyes went directly to hers. They flashed.

Jesus. Seriously?

She shifted her own toward her husband, who was leaning to hear something that the bouncy, redheaded Chloe was saying animatedly in his ear.

Her husband's eyes met hers and he smiled.

She smiled back. Guilt ricocheted inside her, and where it touched her it only spawned more guilt, because there was something pleasing about it.

And then she forced herself to stand there a bit longer, projecting an attitude of not caring about anything or anyone, before gathering up her napkin and drink and the purse she'd set down, and striding away to the bathroom to get herself under control.

She could feel Jasper's gaze on her as she crossed the room, and it breathed on her spine as surely as if he'd had his mouth there, hovering above her vertebrae. By the time she closed herself inside the small room, the sensation had traveled all the way to between her legs, and her panties were wet.

Chapter Two

The familiar routine of coming home from one of these events: yawning in the car into the back of their hands, both of them commenting about how they would have loved to be in bed two hours ago. The clatter of watches and rings on small jewelry dishes, the occasional comment about something they had to do the next day.

"I saw you talking to Jasper," Ryan said, out of nowhere. Vanessa was letting a gold chain coil into a small dish where she kept Ryan's present to her for their fifteenth wedding anniversary, an elaborate gold setting guarding a piece of amber with a long history all the way back to their first date. It was her favorite piece of jewelry.

Ryan's tone was playful: he didn't seem to think much of her talking to Jasper.

"*He's* a piece of work," she said, dryly. She turned to him and smiled. Another flicker of guilt traveled through her: if she was really being honest, if she was really being a good wife, she would tell Ryan everything about that conversation right now. Instead, she was gauging his reaction, deciding how much to say.

Ryan was standing at the opposite side of the bed, unbuttoning the much-too-youthful shirt he'd worn to the event. He was doing it slowly, looking at Vanessa carnally.

Or was he? Was she just superimposing the way Jasper had looked at her on her own husband? They were long past this kind of seduction game, or any seduction game, for that matter. Sex was usually an am thing, slipped in before rushing around and with the hopes that the kids didn't pop into the room needing last-minute signatures on something.

Ryan stopped at the button near his sternum and reached behind him to pull his shirt up over his head from behind. He stared at her as he did.

He definitely seemed to be putting the moves on her. She couldn't help but give him a questioning smile and put her hands on her hips. "He was quite, uh... forward," she confessed.

"I saw that." Ryan tossed the shirt aside and looked at her.

"Oh you did, did you?" she said. She was still gauging Ryan's demeanor. He was acting more like Jasper from that evening than his usual self. He seemed assured that she was going to jump into bed with him, and that prospect was appealing to her - suddenly, overwhelmingly.

And that was crazy. They were talking about his boss, for fuck's sake.

She unbuttoned her own blouse, slowly. She was deliberately teasing him. This was gloriously fun, but it was also guilt-inducing, because she was strip-teasing for her husband, but she was injected with joie-de-vivre by her interactions with Jasper.

A twenty-four-year old jerk. Her husband's boss. Something had to be wrong about this.

"I can't believe you noticed, with Chloe hanging all over you," she said. She said this to make things more even: maybe Ryan was thinking about

Chloe while she was thinking about Jasper. That would make things less "bad." If they were both doing the same thing, it wasn't so bad that her arousal clearly had something to do with the mop-haired little shit that Ryan worked for.

Ryan's eyes closed: a blink, but a slow one. "Chloe is a little twat," he said.

This made her smile. "She's still very attractive."

"Not to me."

Now the air between them was sizzling. She had her blouse undone and she was slowly peeling it away from her body. Ryan was still standing across from her, the bed between them. He wasn't *doing* anything, just staring at her - but that was enough. The air was electric between them. She was feeling very, very horny - and it had been a long time since it had felt like *this*. What was it? An element of danger, of novelty, of something new?

She couldn't think of where to take it next: it was hot, what he'd just said. But was it just her?

Reciprocate?

"*Jasper's* a little shit," she told him. It wasn't the right thing for the mood. She could see it wasn't as soon as she said it. It bounced between them, deflating the building heat a little.

"What'd he say to you?" Ryan asked. She was fidgeting, unsure of where to go with her striptease. "Leave your underwear on. Take off your jeans."

Wow. Okay. She smiled and put her hands to her waist, unbuttoning her jeans - a string of buttons - very slowly. She smiled coyly. "I'm not sure... it's a great idea to repeat it."

And she wasn't. This was a dangerous game. One they hadn't played before. She didn't know where it would take them.

"Interesting. So he *did* flirt with you." Ryan seemed to like this idea. His eyes were on her fingers, separating the buttons of her jeans from the holes. She shimmied very slowly side to side to pull them over her hips. She was glad she'd taken the time to match her underwear and make it sexy - really, this had been because the bra was partially visible through the blouse, but now it was fortuitous planning.

"He said... 'you're the most attractive woman here tonight,'" she told her husband. Sure, that wasn't the thing that stood out most to her. But it was a safe confession. Dipping her toe in the water.

Ryan shrugged, watching her step out of her jeans after getting them down to her knees. "You were. Is that all he said?"

"You don't seem very worried about your boss flirting with your wife," she said. Her eyes went to his jeans and she raised her eyebrows. His cock was hard - rock hard - and that was a pretty new thing at this hour of night.

"That can't be all he said."

She put one knee on the bed, and then the other, shaking her hair out behind her. She played with the straps of her bra, looking at her fingers as if she were adjusting something very important. "It isn't... but, uh..." she looked up at him. "I don't know if I should tell you the rest."

His pants were coming off. "Tell me."

She scooted onto the bed so she could sit back on her heels. She was thinking of what Jasper had actually said to her, and she blushed. She looked off to the side and smiled. "Hmm..."

"Wow," Ryan said. He was climbing onto the bed. "That good, huh? Now you have to tell me."

He looked good, she was thinking. It had been a long time since she'd paid this much attention to him: he was still fit, even though he was forty-

seven. His middle had thickened, his muscles weren't as fierce as before, but he was still very much an attractive man. More than that, he was looking at her with an intensity that she liked. It had been a long time since he'd looked at her like that.

"I... do not want to cause any trouble between you and your boss."

There was a pause, the air simmering in the silence.

"Maybe it won't cause any trouble," Ryan said quietly.

A sizzle - palpable, heated - traveled through her.

"I'm not even sure I heard it correctly," she said.

He reached out and placed a finger on her collarbone. His eyes were following it intently as he traced it down to her sternum, grazed her breast, paused to gently squeeze her nipple through her bra, and then moved closer to place two hands on her ribcage and pull her toward him. "What did you hear?"

"It's crazy," she whispered. His fingers were moving lower, playing with the hem of her panties. She was aroused: she had been all night, partly by Jasper, now by her husband, now also by the guilt of the interplay of those two things.

"Is it?" He asked, and as he did, his fingers slipped into her panties and found for himself how wet she was. She looked him in the eye: this was not displeasing to him. "Tell me what he said."

A grin. Her lips felt out of her control, fluttering. It was all kind of funny, saying it aloud, making her think she must have heard him wrong. But she hadn't.

"He called me... authoritative..." she murmured. "Because I smashed his food with my plate..."

Ryan laughed, breathing out of his nose, but his mind was not really on the joke or what absurd context had brought it about. His eyes were down, looking at her tits, his mind was on what his fingers were finding in her panties. That much was obvious. Maybe he was listening to her, but his attention was divided. His face became serious again very quickly. "And...?"

"And then he said..." She stumbled at this last bit. Ryan looked up instantly, demanding she finish. Maybe he *was* listening. He was almost glaring the conversation out of her, pressing her on with his eyes, which was insanely attractive and another thing that hadn't happened in a long, long time.

It also reminded her of Jasper Cooper. The similarity made something twist in her chest.

"Men like me like women like you," she said softly, quoting Jasper. She struggled to think of the next part, how to phrase it... how had he put it? "Some of us would pay a lot of money.... to... have you... I don't know what he said. Boss him around?"

Ryan's breath left his mouth in a shudder of unmistakable pleasure. "He said that?"

"Ryan!" she said, needing to break up the tense moment with a playful slap. This was getting way too intense, and she was very sure that they shouldn't be playing around like this... not seriously, at any rate.

Ryan laughed, falling back on his heels. He was smiling, but his eyes were still focused on her in a predatory way that made her shiver. "Maybe you can get me a promotion."

"By sleeping with your boss?"

She was joking when she formed that question in her mind. It left her lips as a playful joke, like a reflex. But as soon as she thought about it, really thought about it... it turned into something more inside of her.

His hand had retracted from beneath her panties during that momentary playful move, but he was back, rising to his knees, slipping his fingers in there. His other hand worked the panties down on her backside, caressing her ass, slipping his middle finger down the crack almost to her hole. His lips were close to hers now. "You don't seem to hate the idea," he said.

This was an obvious reference to the liquid between her thighs, to the hardness of her clit, which he rubbed at that moment, making her shudder.

A beat passed, throbbing with her heart. Her veins felt full, her mind light, her nerves screaming with sexual excitement. Either she needed to diffuse this or play along, and either choice seemed risqué and unusual. She dove, making the choice in an instant the way she would have flung herself into a pool of cold water. "Well. If you think it would help your career."

His lips on her shoulder. A small bite, his breath spreading hot over her skin. A seriousness in his muscles, which all seemed to flex at once. The feel of his cock against his boxers and close to her stomach. The bra straps seized and pulled down, taking the bra with them, peeling away and setting her tits loose. "I don't think it would do anything for my career," he said.

"No?" She didn't even know what she was saying or why she was saying it. It was a game of words but the words were no longer important.

"No." He seized her and threw her onto the pillows, climbing on top of her, straddling her. He leaned in and kissed her, and it was passionate. His hands were everywhere, possessively grabbing her like it was fifteen years ago. It was hot.

"I think," he continued, making his way down her body, nibbling and kissing her, his hands leading the charge, getting to the panties and taking them down to her thighs. His mouth hovered over her pussy, hot damp air snaking into her wet crevices and making her squirm. His eyes lifted up to meet hers. "I think Jasper sees something he wants..."

"Because he can't have it," she said.

A smile. "That's not why he wants it." And then his tongue was between her pussy lips, seeking out her clit. His lips found it, sucked it between them, made her jolt. Her hand went to his hair and played with it.

He licked her some more, and she had to fight the impulse to press her cunt against his mouth and smash his head into her pussy. She was tantalizingly, aching close to orgasm after just this interlude.

His eyes were on hers. He lifted his head, leaving her aching, and she mewled softly.

"Would you do it?" he asked her. "He's younger. Rumor has it he's jacked. He's an alpha male, big cock..."

"Ryan!" she exclaimed.

"You could make him do whatever you wanted him to."

This sent an unexpected shiver through her. A pulse of arousal so profound it almost scared her. What the hell game was Ryan playing?

"You could use him. He could be your boy-toy." Ryan's tongue was flicking, teasingly, at her clit. She squirmed, lifting her hips, and Ryan pulled away, smiling.

Ryan was cocky, now. Arrogant. He had a look on his face just like Jasper's.

Her body reacted independently of any thought: it was all done before she even thought a single thing. Her hand seized his hair viciously and she

pushed his face into her pussy. Her teeth were gritted slightly behind her closed lips. Her eyes on Ryan's, his struggling to lift over her mound as his mouth was crammed into her sodden cunt.

She pushed hard against the back of his skull and pulled his hair tightly in her fist. His chin ground into her flesh, his nose into her pubic bone, his tongue and lips squirming in the center of her swollen, wet petals like a trapped fish.

Like that, she thought.

Maybe she even said it aloud. Either way, Ryan did what she wanted, and brought her to orgasm with the pulsing of his tongue.

She tipped her head back and looked up at the ceiling, and even she didn't know how much of that brief time before she came - hard - that she spent imagining Jasper's black hair in her fist, versus her husband's sandy, short cut.

Chapter Three

"Holy..." Vanessa said, as they rolled into the lodge. She had been expecting it to be luxurious - that was, in fact, the principal selling point of this retreat. Or at least the one she would admit to, and the one she was telling herself had been the selling point. Nimbus wasn't known for cheapness. But this was something else.

The last thing she wanted to do with her weekend was spend it watching Nimbus employees playing team-building games at a company retreat. That's what she'd told Ryan when he brought it up. This was weeks after they'd attended the launch party that Jasper had been so brazen at, weeks after the hot sex and the little game of sexual daring they'd indulged in.

Since then, the drama of the moment had kind of died away. But at the mention of the company retreat, Vanessa had to admit that she'd had her fire... er, rekindled.

Still, her first instinct had been to decline. She'd asked if it was mandatory that spouses attend.

"No," Ryan had told her, with a mysterious flicker in his eyes. "But all the employees have to be there. So, you know... me. Chloe..."

And then, when she'd smiled at him through a pointed silence, he'd added, "...everyone."

This had been an unmistakable allusion to that launch party and the subsequent... fling. Ryan had lingered on Chloe's name, given it emphasis. *I'd be all alone with Chloe*, he seemed to be saying. But "everyone" would be there. Everyone. Including Jasper.

"It's a really fancy place," Ryan had suggested further. "All-inclusive if you join me."

"Do I have to play any stupid games?"

Ryan had smiled. "All-inclusive," he had repeated.

Which she supposed meant yes, but she'd decided that she would find a way to weasel out of them. They couldn't possibly expect spouses and significant others to mesh with the Nimbus techy employees, and anyway, hardly anyone at that place was old enough to be married.

She'd agreed. "The free food sold me," she told Ryan.

But what had really sold her on the trip? A flame of jealousy or fear that Chloe would chase after her husband?

A perverse desire to be stuck at a ranch with Jasper, subjected to his forward advances? The whiff of danger about all of that?

It was too late to change her mind, she told herself. Whatever it was like, whatever happened. They were out in the middle of practically nowhere, the mountains on all sides, the cool refreshing sting of late summer mountain air breathing down on them at night.

And free everything. Which was why, she reminded herself, she'd come here. Agreed to come here. Reluctantly come here.

"There's a *pool*?" she asked, astounded.

"Hot springs pool. Nice, huh? The rocks aren't natural, but the water is, I guess," Ryan answered cheerfully.

"Okay," she said, with a sigh of relief. There were horses for riding, and a hot springs pool. She'd be fine. She could just do those activities, far from Jasper Cooper, far from any realism sneaking into her fantasies. "You know where to find me."

It would have been a lie to say that she hadn't taken the time to go shopping for this trip, and it would also have been a lie to say that she hadn't put some extra effort into looking good. She was no slouch when it came to clothing: now that she was in her forties, she felt like she had to up the ante a little bit. But her choices for this weekend had been on the sexier side.

Sexier, but without going overboard. And whether she would ever admit it to Ryan or not, a lot of her thoughts had centered on how Jasper would perceive those outfits when he saw her.

So she was pleased as pie when the receptionist informed them that employees were required to attend an informational session and activity before a cocktail hour and dinner, and that spouses and guests were not to attend. She knew exactly what she would do with that time: put on the new suit she'd bought and get in that hot springs pool, which she sincerely hoped had a hot portion, because it wasn't exactly swimming weather.

She'd splurged on a hot swimsuit and cover-up, and even thought of returning them because the chances of a pool being part of a ranch retreat had seemed slim. Now she relished her decision, because she looked just

that good in this suit. This very, very expensive suit. And the even more expensive cover-up.

The suit was a one-piece, by itself not especially risqué. It swooped low from one shoulder, leaving one shoulder completely bare. On the opposite side of her body, a large half-circle revealed her left flank from under the bra strap to just above her hip bone, cutting inward enough to reveal her belly button. In this way, it was a one-piece that let people know she wasn't afraid of a bikini: she might be "mature," but she still had the goods. The curves of the swimsuit line itself flattered and enhanced her natural soft curves, which were taut from hours at the gym each week. It was elegant and made her look sexy, and the material was dark, rich and obviously expensive.

Coupled with the cover-up, a lace-pattered black tie-up whose patterns mimicked the curves of the suit in smaller fractals, she looked elegant and sporty, young *and* mature, and hot. She had matching sandals with a little heel and a sexy swoop over her ankles, and large, movie-star sunglasses to complete the look.

"Okay, so I am -" Ryan began, coming into the bedroom area from a very luxurious bathroom of polished wood and dark tones, with a huge window looking out on the mountains and which she hoped was one-way glass. Ryan stopped in his tracks. "Whoa."

She smiled at him from where she was leaning forward to a mirror to adjust her dark mascara. "You like it?"

Ryan was behind her in no time at all, hands on her hips, trying to get under the coverup. "You look like a celebrity," he said. "You look... this is new, maybe you need to try it -"

"Do *not* mess with it," she said, laughing. "It takes forever to get it on just right."

This was true. It was skin tight, difficult to reposition, and putting it on took finesse. She'd done it while Ryan was out of the room for a reason.

"But..."

"Stop it, you have to go to a meeting or whatever it is."

"Surely they would understand," he said, lifting the coverup and eyeing her ass. "You look so... tasty."

"Off!" she laughed. "And don't mess up my makeup, don't bump me. This stuff is waterproof, one wrong dot and..." she opened her mouth to touch up a lash.

"Gettin' pretty fancy just to go to the pool by yourself."

"Mmm-hmm," she demurred.

Ryan's hands were everywhere. She nudged him with her ass to back him away.

"You know Jasper won't even be there to see that," Ryan said. She met his eyes in the mirror, mascara wand suspended in the air. He was smiling impishly. This was really the first time - other than the invite to this retreat - that Ryan had indulged in mentioning Jasper in this way. Alluding to what had happened.

She read his face, his tone. He seemed to be teasing her. He seemed to want her to tease back. Something squirmed in her lower abdomen, and a rush of something traveled up her spine, spreading out on her shoulders and making her cheeks feel flushed. A quick glance in the mirror revealed that this was subtle, even if she felt hot.

"Well," she said, making a dramatic deal of selecting a lipstick. "Maybe I have a plan for that."

She did. Kind of. She had an imaginary scenario in her head, in which she would walk out to the lobby in that getup and kiss Ryan on the cheek right in front of Jasper, then slink away with her skin showing through all those lace holes without giving him so much as a glance.

She was that confident about how good her ass looked in this suit. Thinking about all this, she piled her hair up loosely to see what it looked like up, and then let it fall to compare.

"It looks hot up," Ryan said, grinning at her in the mirror from behind. She gathered it again and gave him a look of disbelief.

"You always like it down," she said.

Ryan stepped closer and put his lips on her shoulder. "Yeah but, you know... this looks nice..." He drew a line along her bare neck.

Up it was.

As luck would have it, it did not seem like Jasper would see her on her way to the pool. Plenty of Ryan's colleagues did, however, and they did not hesitate to turn their heads or openly stare at her. She grinned at Ryan, because he was obviously enjoying the ego boost.

Honestly, she was, too. About the time she'd turned forty, she'd felt a loss of male attention - from older men. It had been bringing her down a little: she'd always had an easy time gaining attention from guys and she'd just gotten used to it. The lowered interest from older guys had been noticeable, a little depressing.

But after the night that Jasper had so brazenly hit on her, she'd started noticing something else: *younger* men - much younger men, in some cases - had started following her with their eyes, circulating around her, starting

conversations with her that they had no business starting. In fact, she seemed to be a form of catnip to them.

"Well," she said, as they came to rest in the lobby, where a sign pointed Ryan to his "activity" down the hall. "This is where I leave off to go relax," she said. She leaned in to kiss him, and he smiled and went toward her ear after a brief peck.

"All the guys are staring at you," he murmured. Her smile moved her cheek along his dry, warm lips and made her tingle. "It's hot," he whispered, pulling away.

She tipped her sunglasses from the top of her head onto the bridge of her nose. "Toodles," she told him, feeling very glamorous, because a quick scan of the room around her from behind the dark lenses indicated that, in fact, a lot of them were looking at her.

She turned, living out at least part of her fantasy about walking away in her nice suit.

And then Jasper Cooper, in the flesh, strolled in from the outside, having just stepped out of an *immense* black vehicle and having handed the keys to a valet.

Her heart, admittedly, skipped a beat. She was glad her glasses hid her eyes, so she could take him in without fear of him seeing that she was staring at him. He seemed taller, more assured even than the last time she'd seen him. His wild black hair was mussed very professionally. His t-shirt clung to his lean, muscled physique.

Her eyes dropped to his groin and she jerked them back up. What the hell was wrong with her? Still, the image sank slowly into her cornea: a bulge, indicative of a nicely sized cock -

Oh. My God. What was she even thinking?

Jasper did not try to hide that he was looking at her. And by looking at her, *looking* at her. Top to bottom, eyes lingering on her breasts, her legs, maybe her crotch. A frisson of pleasure raced over her skin.

"You look like a wealthy divorcee," he said. "Vanessa." He stopped, very deliberately in front of her, very much in order to force her to do the same. He put his hands in his pockets, like he would stay for a while. She had no choice but to slow her gait. Someone else was to her right, a large plant to her left.

Her mind whirled for a moment. Blank. She resisted the urge to turn around and see if Ryan was there. She was disarmed. She'd played out a bunch of scenarios in her head about Jasper, but in every one of them she just glided by, tantalizing him. Why hadn't she anticipated this? Jasper was a forward guy.

"That is... not the look I was going for," she said. It was fairly clever. She seemed nonchalant when she said it.

"Pity," he volleyed right back at her.

He did not move, nor make a move to. He was so smug, his face set in a serious expression but an obvious smile in the undercurrents of his facial muscles. There was an obvious, palpable heat between them. Vanessa almost felt like he *had* reached out and touched her. She recognized, not too much later, that she was fantasizing about him doing just that - brazenly reaching out and putting his fingertips on her collarbones, snaking them along the ridge and then down...

She reminded herself that this man - child, practically - was twenty-four years old. She gave her head an imperious shake, but realized that her hair was up and so the gesture would be silly. So she slowed it, tipping her head

a little to look down her nose at him, even though he was a bit taller than her.

His comment about glasses - from weeks before - surfaced in her mind, and she found her hands acting without her brain giving much direction. At least not consciously. She was lowering them to look at him, over the rim of her sunglasses. God, she hoped that fucking mascara hadn't smeared.

"Mr. Cooper, would you mind terribly getting out of my way?"

The hint of a grin. Her comment shifted something in his face, and the electricity of interest shimmered in his eyes. He stepped to the side and stretched an arm out to let her pass.

She did, pleased that he would be looking at her ass as she disappeared out the door.

"Don't be late," he said, making her turn her head.

She shrugged at him. "To?"

Another glimmer of amusement and predation in his eyes. It quivered in the air, reverberating beneath her abdominal skin, bouncing down to her.... well.

"Cocktails. Dinner. I hope your dress is as..." he tipped his head so that it was very obvious that he was looking at her ass. "...tempting."

She turned without saying a word.

Chapter Four

The pool was not as fun as it might have been. For one thing, it was actually quite cool, and evening set in much earlier in the mountains than down on the plains. Which Vanessa knew full well.

Still, it had all been worth it to walk past Jasper in her swimsuit. The thrill of the encounter still hung around in her bloodstream, long after she'd been alone for almost an hour out by the pool. The hot tub section was hot enough, but the air was chilling fast and she didn't want to be uncomfortable afterward, so she sat with her feet in the hot water and savored the interaction with Jasper, while the contours of her guilt began to form in full.

Even though Ryan seemed to be all behind this flirting, she wondered how he would feel if he knew that she *actually* had some attraction to Jasper. If he knew that the excitement of that interaction had traveled southward and now lurked in the fabric of her new swimsuit? That maybe it was more than just a fantasy game to her? Surely he didn't *actually* want her to be attracted to Jasper enough to do anything with him?

Or maybe he did, but he didn't really know how it was affecting her.

And how was it affecting her? She couldn't even say. It wasn't like the attractions of her youth: she didn't picture herself with Jasper, dating seriously, maybe getting married, trying to live a life together. She was freed from thinking about that stuff because she was already married, and happily so. And freed from all of that very mundane and practical stuff, she was free to see Jasper in a purely physical way. As pure fun.

He was young. He was obviously physically fit, full of testosterone. His cock would be hard before they even touched. He had power, he had money. He seemed very willing to trade those things for things he wanted... and the idea of doing something like that? A straight-up transaction for physical acts? If she had to be honest, it kind of appealed to her.

She shook herself - actually, physically shook herself - and blinked her eyes rapidly to kick herself out of the trance she was in. This was all just fun and games. Ryan wasn't serious, she wasn't serious - probably Jasper wasn't even serious. They would just flirt, playing a danger-free version of sexual games, and then go home.

She went back to the hotel room to change, still mildly imbued with guilty feelings. She definitely shouldn't have been taking things this far, even fantastically, in her own mind. She showered, even though she hadn't been in the pool - but it was mostly to rinse away the slick juices that had gathered between her legs and gotten into her new suit, which she rinsed in the shower as she rinsed herself off.

She checked the itinerary for the cocktail party on her phone: starting at 7 pm. Well. It was 630 now, and Ryan wasn't even back. There was no way she'd missed him, and no way he'd already changed his clothes. She texted him before she got in the shower, and there was no response yet. She groaned in frustration: the last thing she wanted to do was get into a hot

dress and head somewhere that no one was dressed up for. That was like being the only person in costume on Halloween. But going down there to check on what was happening would mean everyone would see her.

And why wasn't Ryan getting back to her? The first thing to surface in her mind was Chloe, which wasn't fair to Ryan. But still.

She sighed and started to arrange her outfit and fix her hair. This was probably a case of Jasper keeping Ryan afterward for some kind of discussion, or Ryan doing that specifically to kiss Jasper's ass, which, unfortunately, he needed to do. That was how things worked these days: you worked your ass off in one company, got laid off, and then went to work for a younger dick whose ass you had to kiss.

She smiled, her hands busy with her hair and a flatiron, when she heard the two short vibrations of a text message. Finishing the last strands of her hair, she grabbed the phone, still smiling, expecting to see a text from Ryan there.

Instead, she saw an unfamiliar number. It was a Denver area code, but no other clue was embedded in the digits to tell her who it was. She just knew. A coolness spread through her body.

I held your husband up on purpose. So do what he asks you to.

This delivered a kind of chill that Vanessa had never experienced before. Of course this was Jasper: it was bold, utterly direct, dominating. Questions abounded: what did he want, how did he get her number, what had he told Ryan? Why did he think he could order Vanessa to do "what Ryan asked her to?" The *nerve*.

The sexual implications - do what he asks you to - set off a thousand different sexual ideas and impulses in her head. They were very quickly turned into actual sensations.

It was exasperatingly *hot*. There was some kind of reverberating, sexual symmetry in Jasper's order to do what her husband asked her to do, being written as its own command. A twisted game was embedded in it, as well: the order was really coming from Jasper.

His text was designed to deliver a message: he was in control.

She blinked, her mouth open. What the hell should she do? Did Ryan know about this text? Should she tell him about it, or not?

She should, she definitely should. She absolutely should. She knew this was the right thing to do. She started fixing her hair up and hastily getting into the cocktail dress she had purchased (and, thank goodness, brought - she had almost left it behind). It wasn't a huge deal, as far as dresses went: it was long-sleeved, high-necked, and black. But the material was subtly striped: veins of transparent black fabric ran next to veins of opaque fabric, each one a different texture, material, and thickness than the last. The result was that she was both fully covered and partially uncovered, and there was no pattern to the slits that let the outside world see beneath the dress to her bare skin, except that her nipples and the very center of her crotch were covered.

Her stomach turned and flopped as she looked at it. It was too much. What the hell had she been thinking? She hadn't even shown it to Ryan yet. It had to be worn with no underwear. It was skin-tight. Was she crazy?

She tossed things out of her suitcase even though she knew already: she had nothing else to wear.

She picked up her phone. Still nothing from Ryan.

She hesitated, then pulled on the dress and looked at herself in the mirror. Was it desperate? Did she look like a woman on the prowl? Would it fit in with those other, younger women? Or would she look incredibly out of place? The itinerary had said "cocktail attire."

She picked up her phone and wavered, her thumb hovering over the two choices at the top of her messenger app: Ryan, or Jasper?

As if by magic or reading her mind, Ryan sent a message at that exact moment:

Tied up with something. Just head down to cocktails and I'll catch up with you?

She gave him a thumbs-up, instinctively. Because that would have been the normal thing to do.

Right?

And then she started to type a message to him, after taking a photograph of herself in her dress in the mirror.

Is this okay? I don't want to be overdressed.

But she hesitated.

And then she thought about sending it to Jasper.

She typed out the same message to the unknown number.

And almost sent it. Her fingers paused over the send icon, her heart beating rapidly.

Then she stared at herself in the mirror. What the hell was she doing?

She went back into the bathroom and worked on her makeup. To hell with it. She looked hot as fuck in this dress and it was a cocktail dress. This was

a cocktail party. It wasn't her job to guess about the tastes of some fucking GenZ brats. And she wasn't going to give Jasper any more ideas than he seemingly already had.

She was too old for those kinds of games. She smiled at herself in the mirror, and gave her hair a toss over her shoulder while she pursed her lips with her hands on her hips. Then she scurried into the room and started digging up a bag or purse to carry, because she hadn't counted on not being able to make her husband carry her things for her. And there was no place to put anything in that dress.

Not even underwear.

After futzing with this problem, holding up the two bags she'd brought for the occasion, she tossed them both down and decided to make a bold move. She attached the picture of herself in her dress and sent a new message to Ryan.

*I had to leave my phone in the room. No place to put it.
Bring it for me if you come back here.*

She'd have to leave the key, too.

As she strolled down the hall with her head held high, no keys and no phone, she felt like a badass. This was the kind of thing she'd have never done when she was younger, even in her thirties. Maybe even a few years ago. Maybe even last week.

But she was wearing a skin-tight, very alluring dress, and she looked hot as fuck in it. She didn't need ID, or money (after all, the bar was supposedly paid for like everything else). And she didn't need her phone. In fact, she rather liked the idea that she had left it behind, because it opened all kinds

of possibilities for her - things she could do, places she could go, all the while claiming to have not known Ryan was looking for her.

Dishonest? Somewhat.

But then again, what choice did she have?

"Nothing would fit in this dress," she whispered to herself, before she rounded the corner to the main part of the lodge. Her voice was sexy, and she said the line the way she would to whichever man asked about her phone - whoever that might be.

An attendant was stopping people at the door to the bar, but he crumpled when she walked up to him. He literally crumpled: his mouth opened, and Vanessa looked him squarely in the eye with a hint of challenge in her own eyes. She belonged there: of course she did. And she was hot, and older than this guy, and way out of his league. His mouth closed and he smiled.

Vanessa strolled in.

It was 7:15 and there weren't a ton of people there, but it wasn't empty, either. There was a table with seating arrangements, which she almost approached, but then decided to ignore. Anyone who saw her seemed to fixate on her just a little longer than she was used to. She liked it. It was almost as intoxicating as a full glass of champagne. Maybe more so.

She went to the bar and the bartender went right to her. He was also young, and he also seemed a little flustered in her presence. But unable to stop himself, unable to hide the slavish way he was going to get her whatever she wanted.

In the past, Vanessa had played little games with bartenders like this one. Asking them for a suggestion, flirting with them a little. That seemed so

silly to her now.

Wow, she was getting a big head. She actually did feel like she'd had a lot to drink. She had no basis for this feeling of empowerment except for the fact that Jasper had paid a little attention to her.

And yet... even talking to herself like that wasn't enough to get her to stop.

"What can I get you, ma'am?"

And that might have stung in the not-so-distant past: she hated being called ma'am. Now, she viewed it a little differently, though: in the twisting of the glass in his hands, something in his body language, the way he lowered his chin and his eyes seemed to be unable to find a place to land, she recognized something that she had been overlooking.

This guy was actually intimidated by her. And it was thrilling for him. He was a bald, built, young bartender, and he was calling her ma'am because she was older than him and she was hot, and he didn't have any idea what else to do.

How much booze did she dare to throw on this high?

"Negroni," she said simply. The idea came to her as simply as if she ordered it all the time, but she didn't. It was bold, it was sophisticated, it was strong. It was like the dress she was wearing.

When he looked confused for a moment, she turned away from the bar and laid an arm on the edge of it. He could go find the instructions for that himself. She wasn't feeling so empowered that she could scold him for not knowing, but she also didn't want to explain it to him. It would wreck her vibe.

And there it was: a clear view through the bar and dining area, to a part of the lodge that jutted out to the side. And a clear view into that room -

probably a conference room - and her husband, standing very close to two people. Very close.

And one of those people had curly red hair.

She took this information in with what she could only call equanimity. Chloe bothered her: she was obviously attracted to her husband in some way that frivolous young women are attracted to any good-looking older man. What could she say? She'd been a woman like that not too long ago. And Chloe was peppy, young, attractive as hell. Ryan was standing pretty close to her - closer than he needed to, no matter what -

A flare of anger threatened to rise up from her heart into her throat as Chloe extended an arm and put it around Ryan's waist.

Was she seeing that correctly?

She heard the slide of a heavy glass on the bartop, and so she turned back to the bartender. Her eyes dropped to the drink. He seemed to have figured it out. He was placing an elaborately cut orange on the rim and his eyes darted up to hers before darting back to his fingers.

Did this guy seem... nervous?

He picked it up carefully and set it down on a coaster - a real coaster, made of concentric tree rings and polished wood. "Here you are. Are you waiting on anyone?"

She sat down and crossed her legs, picking up the drink. "No."

This was met with a smile and then the bartender was out of things to say. He smiled nervously and shuffled away, like he wasn't quite sure what to do with himself.

"You're not returning your messages."

This was Jasper, who had appeared as though out of thin air behind her and whose arm was now setting a drink down on the bartop next to her. She

could see this all in a narrow strip of mirror behind the bar. She was rattled, immediately and from head to toe. It traveled through her and then evaporated, but it left her thrown off her game: her eyes took in his lean torso, his hair, the piercing eyes. A faint scent of cedar and citrus preceded his body as he slipped between her chair and the next one over. His eyes were on her drink when she dared to look at him.

She had collected herself by the time he looked up. His full lips were pursed slightly, his fingers drummed confidently on the table. The twist of his mouth moved very little but became a smile. The eyes, startling against his skin, startling with his hair, went very noticeably to the empty lines of her dress, the ones that he could see through. They hovered at her nipples, confirmed what she knew to be true (when she was standing) and then fluttered away to the bartender. He wasn't looking at her when he lifted a finger to get the bartender's attention, nor when he said, "That's quite the ensemble, Mrs. Cole."

She picked up her drink and took a sip of it, smiling just before the liquid touched her lips. The less said to Jasper the better, she figured. But then she remembered Chloe.

"Where have you stashed -" she began, meaning to finish off with "my husband?" But Jasper interrupted her.

"You're not wearing any underwear."

Something took a hold of her. Almost like Sharon Stone or some equally sexual, predatory woman took over her mind for a moment. She smiled, sipped her drink, felt a rush of satisfaction at the comment rather than distaste. "No."

Jasper became a little animated, then. Almost silly. He leaned over the bar and looked around her, then out, over her shoulder. She let him do it.

"Where did you put your phone?"

She smiled again. "Wouldn't you like to know?"

He grinned, actually looking friendly for a moment. "I would, actually. I've been blowing it up for the past five minutes, and you seem like the kind of woman to set your phone on vibrate."

For good measure, he tipped his head and his torso a little, so that she knew he was eyeing her hips and her crotch, assessing for certain that no underwear could be there, hiding her phone.

She gave the side eye, with a smile, and took another sip of her drink. God, whatever this was, it was fun. "It's in my room."

"Too bad."

She shrugged. "What have you sent my husband off to do? With Chloe?"

Jasper looked over his shoulder, precisely in that direction. He shrugged as well. "Corporate stuff."

"Hmm."

"I wanted to get you alone."

Wow. The kid was so fucking arrogant she wanted to smack him. But there was no denying the appeal of it. No denying that it was washing through her as adrenaline and excitement. Her mind was already going to dirty places, and that was not something she needed in this dress. With no underwear on.

"How is it you got my number?" she asked him, because they had just gone right to the edge of her comfort zone already, and she feared going any further with a man as forward as Jasper would end with them fucking in a bathroom within five minutes. And that would be... inappropriate, to say the least. Not something she should be doing.

God. Not something she should even be *thinking* about.

Jasper sniffed. Arrogantly. "I own an innovative cloud storage company. Mrs. Cole."

"Has anybody told you you're an arrogant prick?" She rotated in her chair to look at him.

"Oh yes," he said, without hesitation. He was smiling now, his eyes twinkling. The room was filling up with people, and some of them had clustered to her right, and were actively looking over at them. They said Jasper's name, they were beckoning him to them somehow. They were a blur of sound and shapes to her, her mind was so focused on Jasper himself.

He held her captive for a moment that spread out like an eternity clasped within a second, before leaning toward her so minutely and subtly that she was left wondering if it happened at all. Or if he'd said anything, after she distinctly saw his lips move and felt the vibrations of his voice spread out like fingers across her shoulder blades and the skin of her throat:

"But I've never liked it so much as when you did it."

Chapter Five

She was alone at the bar when Ryan came into the dining area at the opposite end, Chloe next to him. They were chatting amicably. A little too amicably for Vanessa's taste, but with all the dirty thoughts in her head about Jasper Cooper, she knew it wasn't fair to get worked up about it. After all, what if her husband was entertaining fantasies about a younger woman? Wasn't she doing exactly the same thing?

It wasn't like either one of them were going to *act* on it.

Also, she noted with some satisfaction: Chloe's dress was a plain black dress that doubled as a casual suit. Sure, she looked good. She was young and pretty. She had a nice figure and an enviably flat stomach and the sort of tight hips that had never given birth to a child. Her breasts were perky. Her hair was bouncy. She didn't have to color it to chase away the grays.

But Vanessa looked like a femme fatale in this dress, and she knew it. And as soon as Ryan entered the room, he started scanning for his wife. When his eyes landed on Vanessa, he zeroed in with the same intensity as Jasper.

Vanessa moved her eyes to the mirror behind the bartender, to Jasper, then back to her husband as he approached. Both men were looking at her, and

both men had a kind of hunger in their eyes that made something coil up in the lowest part of her abdomen.

She ordered another Negroni for the hell of it. It was unwise; they were strong. But she was feeling... what? A rush, that was for sure.

Ryan didn't even notice the drink. His eyes were on her hips, then her tits, then her hips again. "Ho-ly..." he said. His voice was coarse. His hands seemed to lead him, pulling his body behind their anxious fingers. She slipped off the chair, fully aware that Jasper would see Ryan's hands over the curve of her ass.

He lingered on the varied fabrics - some of which were velvet - with the tips of his fingers. "Are you not wearing any -"

"Okay, everybody," a female voice interrupted on a microphone. "We've been asked to go ahead and take our seats so they can get dinner out to us on time... it's..." This was Chloe, who was being fed lines by a young man who kept flapping his hands at her and mouthing things. "Okay, so it's Wagyu beef or something, with a... what?" she giggled. They conferred. It was all very childish, reminding Vanessa of high school.

Vanessa sipped her drink, leaning sensually on the bar in a way that she knew exaggerated the curves that the dress was already emphasizing. She must have been pretty drunk, she reasoned. She didn't feel like it: but she had to be. Why else would she be looking at the stage the way she was, smiling mysteriously, leaning so provocatively? Who was her audience?

Chloe was still giggling off some instructions. Ryan's attention was not on Chloe, and when she looked in their direction, the fall of her face was noticeable even from where Vanessa was standing. She saw Chloe's eyes harden from all the way across the room.

"Is Chloe after you?" she asked Ryan quietly, with a smile on her lips. She left her eyes on the stage, trained on Chloe. She leaned in close to her husband. Her hand dropped along her side and then lifted to stroke him along his upper thigh. Her torso was closer than for a normal conversation: it was suggestive, too personal for this ambiance. She moved one leg to get her thigh closer to his crotch before pouring herself like a liquid into a different pose.

And why? Partly because it felt good to be so close to his hard form, to a man, like this: an intense sexual awakening was happening inside of her and she felt a lot like she had that night of the company party when she'd interacted with Jasper. Sexual. Sexually desirable. Horny. She actually wanted to fuck: somebody, anybody. Ryan - of course. Because she was married. But at that moment, almost anybody would have done.

Ryan was certainly okay with it, she noted. He was watching her, unable to take his eyes off her dress. A mixture of astonishment and lust mingled on his face. His cock was hard, and she knew it was because of her, not Chloe: it had twitched to life against her moving thighs and hips since he'd gotten here.

"...so please everybody, get settled in," Chloe finished, giggling.

Amateur, Vanessa thought, almost rolling her eyes. She didn't, though: she kept them on Ryan. Sure, a part of her mind was checking her peripheral vision, trained on Jasper and whether or not he was watching her. She couldn't be sure. But she thought he was.

"What has gotten *into* you?" Ryan asked. His hands were at her hips now. He wasn't annoyed. Whatever was happening with his wife, he was happy about it.

People were moving toward their tables. Vanessa could see, but more importantly feel, Jasper's eyes lingering on her. So she leaned in closer to Ryan, her hand behind his neck, stroking him. "Is there any way we can blow this off?"

Ryan smiled, picking up the drink from the table and looking into it as if he could find an explanation for his horny wife there. "I... really don't think... that would be in my best interests..." he managed to say.

"No?" she asked, brushing her fingers over his cock as she turned toward the bar. She picked up the drink. "Are you sure?"

Ryan was shaking his head slowly, staring at her. No, he wasn't sure. He also didn't know what to make of her.

That moment sizzled for what seemed like a long time. Vanessa was getting so worked up she felt like she might explode. A desire like this - to *fuck*, at an inappropriate time, to hell with the social repercussions - had not gripped in her twenty years. Sure, she liked sex, but she always had it under control. She wasn't reckless. She didn't suggest things like this.

"We really need everyone to get seated, please." This was Chloe, voice somewhat shrill, from the front of the dining room. Someone made a joke, and Chloe made a fake grimace in his direction. "It's about the *beef*," she said.

Laughter.

Jasper moving in her vision.

"Shall we?" she said. She and Ryan were still staring at each other. She liked letting it hang in the air: which thing was she suggesting that they do?

"The seats are assigned," he said.

"Mmm," she demurred. She liked the shudder that went through him. "So where are we?"

"You might like it," he said.

"Oh?"

"You might not."

She smiled. She already knew what was coming.

Ryan leaned toward her. "But you have to promise to behave yourself."

They were inches from each other. Between them, the air was hot. Both of them were radiating a sexual heat, and wafting from between their bodies was the unmistakable, though subtle, scent of Vanessa's pussy.

She shifted to set down her Negroni. It was inadvisable to finish it. As she moved, her thighs glided against each other easily, slickened by the juices that had crept from inside her.

Up on her toes - Ryan was tall, even taller than her heels. Jasper was taller. Her lips against his cheek. Her fingers in his hair, her body acutely humming with the thrill of knowing that Jasper was watching. "My thighs are wet," she whispered.

And then she turned and walked boldly toward the table where Jasper was standing, because she knew where they were seated. She pulled her husband along behind her. And met Jasper's eyes the entire time.

Dinner. She was across the large table from him. She moved her hand to Ryan's knee, and then to his lap. She turned to the person next to her and chatted amicably: he was young, geeky. His girlfriend was next to him, mute and shy. She had no idea what they talked about. Her fingertips found the tip of her husband's cock and she made a circle of her fingers to massage up and down on as much of the crown as she could subtly identify.

She ignored it but smiled inwardly when his leg jerked next to her. Precum was rising through the surface of his dark pants.

Chloe was next to Ryan, on the other side. Courses of salads and steaks and weird little dishes of farm-to-table food that Chloe crowed about in a strange vocabulary rotated on and off Vanessa's plate. Ryan was sweating at his hairline. Jasper was talking to whoever talked to him, but whenever Vanessa saw his face he was staring at her coolly. There was no way of knowing what he was thinking.

She wanted it to be about sex. She wanted it to be about sex with her. It was childish and ridiculous, but what was a little fantasy that stood no chance of becoming real?

Nothing. She was having fun. Her hand was on her husband's cock, after all. There was something delicious in the whole scene: she was turned toward the geeky boy, chatting amicably; her fingers were forming gentle massage pillows on her husband's cock, and Jasper was watching it all. She knew he was. He was watching it, and thinking about her. Sexually.

Dinner was winding up. She turned to Ryan, her eyes tracking Jasper as she did, and she put one arm on his shoulder to place her mouth close to his neck. Her other hand went to his legs again. He looked nervous, then he looked down. "When can we get out of here?" she purred.

"I have some bad news," he said. A burst of laughter and clapping was drowning out their voices. "You can go any time you want... but I can't."

She read her husband's face. They both seemed to be on the same page about all of this: it wasn't as if he didn't know that Jasper figured somewhere in her sexual excitement. It wasn't as if he didn't also understand that her sexual excitement also had everything to do with him, her husband.

Chloe grasped Ryan's arm. "You ready for this?" she asked, in a sing-song, cheerful voice. Then she thrust a hand into the air. "Ryan's on *my* team," she yelled.

Ryan looked at his wife apologetically. "I really... really..." he began. His cock twitched under her fingers. She blinked at him. "Wish I didn't have to..." Ryan finished. "You can stay, but..."

Vanessa considered it. She could feel Jasper looking at her. Surely Jasper had to stay, too? How would that play out?

How *could* that play out?

God, she was so drunk and horny. She had better go back to the room before she did anything crazy.

"Okay," she said. Performatively, she nuzzled him. "I'm disappointed. But I also need the room key."

Ryan looked puzzled. She leaned away from him to remind him of what he was missing. "I couldn't put it anywhere," she told him, drawing a line with her finger down the length of her torso, lingering on the curve of her breasts. "Obviously."

Ryan was gritting his teeth. "You could wait up for me," he said. Lower: "You *should* wait up for me."

"We'll see," she told him suggestively. "Have fun with Chloe."

Ryan leaned in close to her. "You know that Jasper has been looking at you all night."

She smiled. She withdrew. She gave him a simmering look. And then she slipped the key card from under his fingers and stood up in one fluid movement, so that Jasper got a nice view of her ass. And then she walked out, without looking back, thighs slipping past each other, greased and, strangely, quivering.

Chapter Six

The key card didn't work.

She tried it multiple times, becoming extra annoyed: she was on such a high from the evening, she had already been planning on masturbating and barely able to wait for it, just walking back to their room. This delay was unexpected. Aggravating.

She pressed it to the door for a final try, and glowered at the red light. *Why?* Of all the irritating things that could -

Her mind didn't take long to catch up, to start wandering to nefarious explanations and possibilities. Most of which started with Chloe. Did Chloe have their real room key? Had her husband given it to her?

She sighed. What purpose would that serve? Vanessa was the one in the room all the time.

Unless... was this Chloe's key card? Had Ryan taken it from her? Or had Chloe slipped it in?

Vanessa flipped the card around in her fingers, leaning against the door. The card didn't have a room number on it, obviously. Chloe, to tell the truth, didn't seem stupid enough to do something like that, and Ryan certainly

wasn't stupid enough to give his wife the wrong card in the event that he actually *had* Chloe's key card.

It appeared to be a plain, old-fashioned mistake. Timeless. The malfunctioning hotel room card.

It was still annoying. She'd have to go all the way back to the lobby (the ranch was spread out, mostly, on one lengthy, rambling floor with two wings. Her and Ryan's room was about as far from the lobby as one could get.

She slipped her shoes off, one at a time. She could at least take a different route, exploring a little. She suspected that there was an entrance to the pool area if she just tucked down one of the corridors, so maybe she could locate that on the way down, waste some time soaking her feet in the hot tub part, and then the Nimbus crowd would be out of the dining area for sure and she could get another glass of wine.

She found the entrance to the pool - it was not, after all, that hard to find, and stepped outside. Now, it was downright chilly. But she was still warmed up from the inside out, and the cool stone paving felt nice on her feet. Carrying her shoes by the heels, she sat down - hiking her dress up over her ass to avoid snagging the delicate material - and plunked her feet in the hot tub.

Bliss. She leaned back on her hands and looked up at the stars, then closed her eyes. The cold stone against her thighs and ass, the heat curling around her feet, the sexual fire between her legs that was slowly waning with this unexpected interruption... it all felt really good. She felt her nipples pebbling beneath the skirt fabric. It was fairly indecent, the way she was sitting there with her totally bare legs hanging out and next to nothing of the dress covering her pussy, but she was unconcerned about it.

This was, in fact, probably just the cool-down she needed. She smiled to herself with her eyes closed. She was really letting herself get carried away with this Jasper fascination. But what was the harm of it? Ryan was probably having the same kind of fun with Chloe. It was all harmless if nothing came of it, and nothing probably would.

Thinking about Jasper, though... his lean torso, his arrogant face, his thick black hair... it did all combine to make a very enticing fantasy. Before she knew it, she was sinking into a fantasy, Jasper at the center of it. If he were only in this hot tub with her, water streaming down his firm, lean pectoral muscles, his unblemished skin, his black hair damp in tight ringlets, looking at her with those green-gray eyes as he stepped closer. He'd have his hands out, the wiry strength of his fingers coiled for action, longing to touch her...

She pictured him getting closer, and her legs parted slightly with her fantasy. She was aware of this, but did it anyway: she was facing the wing of the lodge where there were only two rooms and both of them dark, beyond that, just the mountain-desert landscape, empty of everything and dark and cool. Her pussy was wet, and the crisp mountain air swirled over her skin in curled patches that mingled with the humid steam of the hot water.

She opened her eyes and sat up straighter, but kept the fantasy running in her head. She overlayed on the scene in front of her: Jasper, looking at her the same way he had in every other moment when she'd seen him: eyes intent, wolf-like. Hunger evident. Arrogance high, desire feral, dick hard. She gave it no thought whatsoever to slide her right hand up and over her bare thigh, resting it along the crease, the bunched-up dress along her thumb and wrist, her skin underneath her palm.

It was nothing - perfectly casual - to slide her fingers down to her pussy, to seek her clit almost discreetly with her pointer finger. When she touched herself, her fantasy-Jasper did, too - but not before lowering his wolf-like eyes and mouth very near to the surface of the water, so that when he touched her, it was with his tongue.

Her left fingers, supporting her on the stones, curled as if they actually held the thick black curls of Jasper's head in their grip. She scraped a knuckle on the stone and barely noticed it. She was staring, lips parted, out at the darkness and the darkened rooms of the lodge, at an empty hot tub that spilled into an empty black pool... so she knew that Jasper wasn't there to lick her pussy and make her come, and no one was there to see her masturbate. But still. There was decorum to be maintained.

It didn't take long - this fantasy was so raw, so within her grasp, so close to reality - that she came within just a few minutes. She merely shuddered, because yelling would be too dramatic and too unlike her, anyway. The shudder was violent, trapped within her muscles and her rigid posture: it sent chills along the backs of her legs and arms, made her thighs tremble, and shook her once from head to toe. Her climax had come just as she'd pictured Jasper rising from the water, cock in hand, ready to seize her and fill her pulsing pussy with the full length of his very hard, very large cock.

Her vision shifted: the fantasy evaporated. The cold night air swept over her in a gust and she grew quite cold. The raw heat of desire that had driven her to masturbate - ! - at the edge of a pool disintegrated, leaving only a bit of lurching shock and pulsating shame in its wake.

"Jesus," she said in a whisper. She looked down at her legs as she slipped her right hand back to the stone deck and tried to compose herself.

Later, she would think about it - of course she would - and she would remember hearing the quiet unlatching and latching of a door. A click, unmistakable, followed by the sound of pressurized air sweeping out - very low, very dull, very easy to deny having heard at all. A low scrape, the sound of rubber across stone. A low thud, a barely audible click.

When had it all happened? Who knew, exactly. But she *had* heard it all. Right in the middle of Jasper's approach to her in the pool, in her fantasy. Somewhere in there. And she had registered it - far, far below layers of conscious thought and unconscious thought and desire. Someone was quietly opening a door behind her. Quietly closing it. Quietly observing her.

But her orgasm had obliterated the thought, somehow. The loudness of the silence outside, only the splashing of water against the sides of the rock pool, the dull roar of mountain air out there in the distance, fighting to be heard over the pulsing of her blood in her ears. It had all been a fantasy: Jasper in the pool, Jasper's hair in her fingers... so she threw that opening door in with the whole lot.

What had she imagined? Her husband? Or Jasper? Surely she hadn't really thought it was anyone else, or she wouldn't have remained cocooned in her fantasy, masturbating at the side of the pool.

She could smell her pussy. She was shaky. Her toes found the bench in the hot tub and she stood up to smooth out her bunched-up dress. Only when she did this did she consider the view from behind: if anyone was there, they got a full glimpse of her bare ass when she stood up.

She was just thinking of what spectacle she could have made of herself, but also that it was *fun* - exhilarating, anyway - to be doing something like this. Masturbating because she was so heated up by a real-life situation, in her forties, who would have thought? This was the thought that made her

closed lips turn up in a smile as she turned on the bench and waded toward the steps to her left, to exit the hot tub without having mussed her dress at all.

Hand on the railing. The water glimmering beneath her, lit up by a weak, soft light in the hot tub. The smell of pine. The sound of the door opening and closing surfaced like great beast from beneath the ocean: *that had really happened. So a real person was here.* And then she looked up.

So it was both a shock and none at all to see Jasper Cooper standing there. Hands in pockets. Just feet away from a second door that led to a corridor that led to the lobby - all this, she could see from where she was.

It struck her hard in the face, cold in her chest, making her veins run with ice water, and she froze.

But it also didn't: it seemed simultaneously as expected as if it were scripted, and the heat that had escaped from between her legs with her orgasm simply rekindled. The shakiness of her post-orgasmic physiology shuddered away like a shiver. She paused, hand on the railing, cold and hot all at once.

Jasper's expression didn't change. He waited. His eyes were visibly sea green and contrasted against his tan skin even in this dismal light.

She looked down to step up, smiling as she did. Beneath her skin, extraordinary things were happening, but somehow she felt very calm as well.

"What are you doing, standing there like a ghost?" Her tone was like something she'd have used on a child. An adolescent.

Jasper didn't react to it. He stepped closer while she stood by the top of the stairs. She smiled and leaned against the railing. "How long were you there?"

This was as much an admonishment as an invitation.

A tip of his chin. His lips - striated when spread, pink, full - formed something between a smirk and a smile. "You knew I was there."

A shudder began at the base of her neck and wrapped around her like arms, pointed toward her pussy. She could feel the slickness between her thighs. She was grateful for the length of the dress. She became suddenly aware that her nipples were hard as rocks and that it was visible to Jasper, if he was looking. Which he was.

They moved at the same time. Toward her shoes, set down as if staged, one heel tipped over, the straps loose. Even her shoes looked sexy, even without her feet. Jasper was there before she was, in two long strides. They were facing each other, and neither could easily reach down to pick the shoes up.

"Seriously," she said quietly. "What are you doing here?"

"Who were you thinking about?"

The question was so bold, so unexpected, that it literally froze her from head to toe, mouth open. She had no idea what to say.

Jasper's eyes were on her body, and when they were done with that, they moved to her lips. Somewhere in the middle of this lingering look that fell on her body more like his fingers were actually caressing her, his hand brushed up from between them. The back of it, the veiny strength of it folded in a light curl. From her pubic bone, to her navel, to her sternum, and then her throat. A light touch that spread out in waves of hard lust through every part of her body. His curled fingers stopped just beneath her chin and applied almost no force to tip her face up toward his.

Her breath was actually caught in her throat. A sudden thought: was she just fantasizing again? She became disoriented by this idea, because it

seemed all too real. And yet it couldn't - it shouldn't - be happening.

"D...don't you have to lead your team to victory, through innovative solutions to -"

"No." He cut her off in a quiet and insistent voice. His fingers moved over her lips, brushing them slightly. "I do what I want. I'm the boss."

He sank his eyes into her body like teeth after saying this, while she reeled from it. He didn't stop looking at her as he began to lower himself down toward the ground. Her eyes followed him. Her body craved the very wrong thing that all of this insinuated was next: she could almost feel his head between her hands, his curls in her fingers, his hot breath between her thighs, his fingers at the backs of her knees...

Her heartbeat had gotten so loud in her ears that she feared he could hear it.

That wouldn't do. She brought her breathing under control. Jasper was just picking up her shoes. He was standing back up again.

He was closer to her. So close that when she breathed, her breasts - and her hardened nipples - just touched his shirt. His hand on her shoulder, brushing her hair back. Cool mountain air, sending a shiver through her. Somewhere down below, his fingers against her thigh, the dangling heels of her shoes clattering, goosebumps racing everywhere. His knuckle indented her dress, a pad of his finger found a thin membrane in the lines of her dress and swiped along it, sinking into her soft pussy flesh and surely sensing the juices behind it. "Who did you think about?" he whispered.

Her mind splintered off in a thousand directions. In one, she was indignant and slapped him. In another, she stepped away in horror and told him they couldn't do this. In one, she ran away. In none of the directions

that her mind went in that split-second, however, did she even *think about* doing what she actually did.

Her left hand closed around the straps of her shoes. Her eyes went down to assure herself that she had them in her hand, and when she did, she saw the bulge in his pants and it made her pussy ache. Maybe a decision was made right there, maybe not: but it seemed to congeal inside her mind that no matter what Ryan said or did or thought about this, no matter what Jasper did, for that matter - it was all going to end with that cock between her legs.

Her right hand traveled up with her eyes. She met his eyes evenly, serenely. She knew that she appeared to be in control of herself, from Jasper's point of view: she could see the flicker of competitiveness, a spark of interest, a challenge lighting up in his eyes. She was no more in control of herself than she had been just moments before, so this was more like watching a movie than anything else:

As she lifted the fingers she'd had in her pussy while masturbating and slipped the very tips between her lips. Closed them down sensually. Captured every single ounce and grain of the man's attention, making his eyes focus on her mouth and then become fixed enough to diagnose him with de-cerebration. A victory flared in the most primal part of her mind, lust swelled in her lower abdomen. The taste of her own pussy coated her lips and the tip of her tongue. A faint kissing sound whispered between them when her fingers left her lips. "Wouldn't you like to know?"

Her fingers left her mouth, moving out, descending. From there, she had been planning to put a hand on his shoulder to push him aside, stroll past him, go inside. Already, milliseconds after pronouncing this, she regretted it

and didn't know what to do. Her mind was starting to reel, and tilt: that had been so provocative, and she wasn't *really* ready to back it up.

Jasper's face changed. His eyes hardened into determination and lust. Air left his nostrils, a laugh that could not escape through his closed mouth. His lips were forming a half-snarl, half-smile. Something very much reminded Vanessa of a panther in that moment. Fixated on its prey.

His hand moved so fast that she had no time to react. Her amygdala sensed it and sent a shot of wild adrenaline into her bloodstream, an expectation that she was about to be choked. Primal, staggering fear for less than a second, detached from any thought: the way a panther's prey must feel in the very final milliseconds before teeth sink into its neck.

But his hand landed on her skin with a delicate touch. Firm, commanding, placed as though he had taken a lifetime to find it. Four fingers on her spine, at the base of her neck. His thumb very, very delicately on the hollow of her throat, stroking it. Pressure at the back of her neck, his eyes flashing one final time.

His lips were warm and dry. Assured. It was an aggressive kiss, one designed to claim her, not explore her. She was so stunned that she did nothing, while he moved inside her mouth and against her, his teeth being the last thing to scrape over her lower lip as he pulled away.

She exhaled. A shoe started to slip from her fingers. She had to fight very hard against something inside her that was pushing her torso toward him.

His hands went to his pockets. His eyes up at the sky. Down at the ground. He scraped something on the ground with his shoe. "You wouldn't have gotten very far," he said. "Without this."

"It isn't working." She was very, very relieved to hear her voice leave her mouth, the words coherent and not shaking like her thighs, which she flexed

to steel herself. The ground seemed to be shifting under her feet. She had never, never, never ever cheated in any way on her husband in *18 years* and now all of that clean record was wiped away and gone.

"Isn't it," Jasper said, smiling openly now. Another doubtful statement: how bold and arrogant and bullshit of him.

He was scraping the card up now with his foot, hands in his pockets. Almost boyishly. Jesus Christ, this guy was far, far closer to her eldest son's age than to hers. Panic rose up, and then blessedly fell as quickly inside her. It was an indiscretion. Mostly Jasper's fault. They would laugh at each other and say this, she would walk off now, and that would be the end of all of it.

All she had to do was put her hand to her mouth in horror. Turn and stalk to the door to her corridor. "This didn't happen," she would say. And then she would stay away from him, forever.

He lifted his head and met her eyes. They were further apart now. His hands were safely in his pockets. She tried to make herself move, but she couldn't.

Say something.

Do something.

Jasper waited. His arrogant face was beaming a message to her, that the ball was in her court. If she didn't slap him, or run away, or say something, it would be open season. He was, in fact, a little jumpy, energy coiling in his muscles and his eyes lit up with a competitive gleam, like he was on the other end of a court, awaiting the volley of his opponent.

He certainly wasn't the kind of man to *apologize* for what he'd just done.

No, Jasper was not that kind of man.

He lifted his thumb to his lips after a moment of silence between them, wiped it, looked at it briefly, and then put it in his mouth. "You taste good."

Her eyes flicked to the door to the right of his sensual body. Someone, thankfully, was coming down the hall. She folded her arms and stepped to the side. "Someone's coming." She was concerned - she was screaming inside. But she sounded calm as a glassy lake.

"You better go inside, then." He was amused. He would do whatever she cued him to, including fucking her right here on the cold stone ground under the stars and in view of anyone who happened to walk by. All she had to do was tell him to. She could have his jaw, which was covered in the finest of grainy, sandpaper stubble, between her thighs and that obnoxious hair wound in her fingers in less than a second if she just told him to.

Her eyes flicked to the door. A keycard reader was next to it. Of course. She lifted a foot, stone-faced, and slipped one shoe onto her foot, then the other. She stared at him the whole time. She wasn't sure what she was radiating to him: she didn't even know how she felt. The feel of his lips still lingered on her own. Guilt and pleasure clanged around in her chest while her mind raced uselessly from one thought to the next.

"You need me to let you in," he told her, as if he was just getting some message from her. His head tipped back. That was fine: he could wait. He could hunt some more. He could toy with his prey. He stepped aside and put an arm out, toward the door. "Of course."

She drew her left foot out wide to step in front of herself and begin walking toward the door. If she turned around at that outside wall and lifted her skirt, he would fuck her, right there. This was certain. He would lift her by her thighs and sink that sizable cock into her pussy and fuck her.

He was right behind her when she stopped in front of the door. She could feel him, almost as though tentacles reached out from him and lapped at her

skin. He brushed her arm as he tapped his own key to the fob. The door clicked, she opened it, he held it by the top and pulled it open.

His fingers trailed down her spine to her ass as she walked away.

She did not look back. She looked down, to see if water was dripping down her shins, or if that was juice from her pussy that had made it all the way there. Her thighs were slick. She felt disembodied. Her pussy ached.

She was smiling to herself.

She gave her hair a toss over her shoulder as she turned the corner.

Chapter Seven

The smile disappeared from her face as soon as she turned the corner and could see past the lobby, into the dining area, and through the windows to the rooms beyond, where indistinct figures shifted in the glow of the lights. None were Ryan or Chloe in particular, but Ryan and Chloe were there.

Her husband was there. With the Nimbus people. Doing business things.

The floor seemed to shift beneath her feet and the lights glared menacingly at her: this was a new time, a new place. Everything had changed, because of what had just happened.

Flashes of her interaction with Jasper materialized before her eyes and then disappeared. She took her shoes off again because they hurt her feet. Jasper's green eyes hovered in front of her face and the phantom of his thumb traced the mesh line of her dress over her pubic bone.

A smiling receptionist was blinking at her.

Behind her, Vanessa sensed the loping figure of Jasper, strolling down the hallway. He passed behind her and she remained fixated on the receptionist. "I seem to have misplaced my room key," she said, in a very low voice.

Jasper was to her left now, walking calmly. Arrogantly, the way Jasper did. He was a man she had only met twice and she recognized his gait. A sort of radiation came off of him and landed on her left flank, buzzed against the skin of her neck. His hands were in his pockets.

Vanessa was leaning on the counter, shoes in hand. The receptionist was telling her something. What was it?

Her lips tingled. They felt stained to her, and it seemed like the receptionist was looking right at them, as though she could see the treachery painted into her mouth, like dye.

Jasper was gone: all that remained of him was the shape of his body and his black hair, disappearing down the hallway. Soon he would be in the same room as her husband. Traces of her pussy smeared on his lips, somewhere in his mouth.

"Sorry, what was that?" Vanessa said, because the receptionist was staring at her as if she expected her to answer.

Would Jasper stroll into that room, with those activities, and shake Ryan's hand? The little shit probably would. He'd probably do that first thing. God, she hated herself right now.

"I need some kind of identification," the receptionist was saying.

Vanessa felt a swell of exasperation. "I don't have any, that's the thing - I..." She stepped back and showed off her dress. "Nothing fits in here. So I left everything in the room."

The receptionist was smiling blandly. "I understand," she said, like she didn't at all. She was playing with a piece of paper, sliding her fingers along

the top of it and then doing it again, and Vanessa venomously hoped she would get a paper cut.

Vanessa pointed behind her. "I had the key, my husband's key... and I just went back there, and it didn't work, and then I left it in the pool area. By mistake."

An even more pained smile. "You came from the pool area?"

Vanessa already knew where this was going, and she suddenly wanted to retreat. She sighed. "Yes, okay, I went through that way without realizing that it locked..." her voice trailed off. She pointed aimlessly in the direction that Jasper had just walked.

"But you must have had a key to get in," the receptionist said. Then she looked around, leaned forward. She was still moving her nimble, manicured fingers along the top of the paper. "Were you with Mr. Cooper? Just now? Is that your husband?"

The full weight of what had just happened, now that it was basically spelled out in plain English for her by the receptionist, hit Vanessa in the face again. She felt exactly as if she'd been smacked by a dodgeball: the same ping, the same rubbery smell, the same smattering of stars in her eyes.

The receptionist's eyes went to her shoes. Then to her lips again. Then slid to the hallway. "Or... you're not with... you're..."

A silence lingered between them as she added it all up: the shoes, the dress, the pool area, the retreating multi-millionaire boss, the room key, the incomprehensible story.

It's not what you think, Vanessa wanted to scream at her. But the deafening silent scream of the word "whore" drowned even that thought out.

"So you're with Nimbus," the receptionist said. The paper sliding had stopped.

"I'm - yes. And no. I'm a spouse. I... can you just look me up?"

She was shaking her head, lips pressed together. Admonishment in her eyes. "Could you use your phone? To maybe get him - someone with an ID? Down here?"

Vanessa looked around her with desperation. The black void of the outdoors that surrounded the lodge seemed to swallow up the world. Where on Earth did this crazy bitch think she had come from, if she was just an intruder trying to break into a room?

She almost started this fight, but thought better of it (thank god).

"Look," she said, smiling sweetly. "I didn't have my phone either." If a key wouldn't fit in the dress, how would a phone? she seethed inwardly. "So... I mean, could you maybe just open the door for me and I could get my ID and show it to you?"

This showed promise. But then she shook her head slowly, making a face. "Is he here? Your husband?"

"Yes, of course, it's just..."

There was an awkward smile on the receptionist's face. She was going to make her say it.

"Look," she sighed. "I'd really, really rather not interrupt them, while they're doing their thing in there - you know how it is."

She did not. Her head was moving, albeit haphazardly, in another slow shake, and her lips had been retracted inward in the classic "that's a real problem you've got" shape.

"You could have a drink at the bar while you wait?"

"I don't have any money, though, do I?" Vanessa spat.

"You could charge it to your room..." She seemed to immediately catch the absurdity of that. She reached for a phone. "Hold on, while I call -"

"Look, no, okay, that's not necessary. I'll just... I'll go and try to catch his eye. Okay? Thank you."

"I was going to say, I can call Mr. Cooper. If you like. He can verify who you are, I take it?"

"Oh God, no, don't call him, he's... I don't want to make a spectacle. He's, uh... the boss. Of my husband. So."

The receptionist had to force a neutral expression. The lips pressed even harder together. The paper-fingering started up again. Without warning, she seemed to take pity on Vanessa. "Let me see if I have another contact. Okay?"

Vanessa looked through the dining room, squinting at the shifting figures through the opposing windows. A dull echo of a cheer echoed through the hallway as people lifted their hands in the windows. Scattered clapping.

"I have a contact," the receptionist said, smiling brightly. "Hold on one moment."

The lights in the room dimmed. Vanessa put her shoes back on as elegantly as she could manage. Her mind whirled: where was Jasper, what was he thinking? Did Ryan know, already? Would she tell him? Did she have to? Jasper's body and face and eyes and hard cock sprang to life in her thoughts like wack-a-moles.

The receptionist's hand on the receiver, head tilted. "Ma'am? Your name?"

"Vanessa. Cole." A swallow, dry and hard.

"Okay yeah, I'll tell her, thanks." She hung up. She shifted some papers. "A Chloe Whitehouse... Whitehall? She'll be right down."

Good. Fucking. Lord.

"Oh Van-essa!" Chloe said, in the most cloying and bitchy corporate tone Vanessa thought she'd ever heard. She should know. She used it all the time. Chloe was walking toward her with her hand extended, like they were meeting for a real estate deal.

She at least keyed in on that as soon as she got within five feet of Vanessa, at which point she laughed. "Oh gosh. Of course. Old habits." She turned to the receptionist. "This is Vanessa Cole, yes. She's married to one of our *best* sales reps." Chloe turned to Vanessa and cocked her head. "How did you lose your key, Ms. Cole?"

The absolute fucking nerve of this bitch, Vanessa thought. Chloe was really a master of bitchiness, she had to give her that. The mizz. After using her first name. The over-sweetened, putrefying accusation in her tone, glazed over by her pretty smile and bouncing red curls.

"Long story, Chloe," Vanessa said curtly. She turned to the receptionist. "I'm in room 151."

"Oh!" Chloe said. Vanessa turned to her.

"You're on the first floor," Chloe said, as if this was the basement. "That's... nice. Easy access to the pool." She turned her attention to the receptionist, who was already swiping Vanessa a new card. "While I'm here... I need a new card as well. Two-twenty-six."

She turned to Vanessa. "I seem to have misplaced mine."

There was absolutely zero way of reading this. Chloe seemed perfectly frank, totally neutral. On the other hand, she was a little witch, and she wasn't an idiot: she had to know that Vanessa had been given a card by

Ryan. She'd witnessed it. Was she actually *pointing out* that the card was her own room card?

Vanessa took the new card from the receptionist, who was studying the high-intensity volley between the two women with a wary eye. She cleared her throat. "Of course." Her eyes went back and forth between them a few times.

"Thanks so much, Chloe, for interrupting your, uh... activity. I'm *so* sorry," Vanessa said, as icily sweetly as she could.

"Oh, it's absolutely no problem. I'm Jasper's right-hand woman. That's why I'm here, to be on call. For any problems that arise. Jasper's far too busy to handle this.... kind of thing himself." She snapped her own new card out of the receptionist's fingers. "Thank *you*. Well, Ms. Cole. I hope I don't see *you* again. Tonight, that is. I'll see you tomorrow, of course. We've got loads of things planned, and we want all the spouses included. It's going to be so fun!"

Vanessa nodded, a plastic smile glued to her face.

Wouldn't it just.

Honesty was the best policy.

Absolutely.

Always.

But there was just one, tiny, niggling thing about that:

Chloe's lost key card.

Well, two little things about that: telling the whole, complete truth about Jasper would require telling a whole, complete story about masturbating.

Where Jasper could see her. Naturally, Ryan would probably ask the same question that Jasper asked.

But back to that card, because it was easier to get her head around. Because if Chloe *had* given her card to Ryan, and that had been the reason that the card Ryan had given Vanessa hadn't worked... well, then... that was a whole different story.

The question was, did she wait for her husband to confess to that, before she confessed to her own sins? They would, very much, be even-Steven in that case.

It didn't seem like Ryan, if she was being honest. Chloe, though? Could she have slipped it to him without telling him?

Vanessa shook that thought away while she paced in the room. It didn't make any sense. Ryan was a lot of things, and he might have even been capable of taking a room key from Chloe - but he didn't seem so stupid as to give it to his wife by mistake.

And did any of that really negate what she'd done? She hadn't known about this room key business prior to letting Jasper kiss her.

Jasper kissed her, she repeated to herself. That much was true. Sure, she'd let it happen. Sure, she could have seen it from a mile away. But what else could she have done?

She paced some more. The truth was fluttering around in the room with her, a lost bird that needed to be let out: she didn't want to tell Ryan about Jasper. She didn't want to complicate their marriage, or hurt him. She didn't want to be a bad wife.

No, that wasn't the problem.

The problem was... she didn't really want it to be the end. Of whatever it was with Jasper.

She sat down on the bed and picked at her lip - an old, disgusting habit that she only did when she was nervous and an adolescent. She saw herself doing it in a full-length mirror and dropped her hand, ashamed. She grew impatient. She was still wearing her dress and no underwear...

She could go out there. To the pool. To the hot tub. She could get the key. She could take it to the room... what room had Chloe told the receptionist?

Her eyes went to the window, through which she could see a portion of the pool area, the shifting lights beneath the water and their odd, fragmented glow on the building. The card was out there.

She racked her brain for Chloe's room number. She hadn't, at the time, seen the point of committing it to memory. She began to devise fantastical, impossible ideas in her head: putting on a suit, going out to the hot tub. That would be cover for her being there.

But why would she be on the second floor? That much she knew: Chloe had said two-something.

There would be no reason for her to be upstairs. It was all so ridiculous. Still, she kept thinking about it, plotting. Why? The card was scraped up, it probably didn't work anymore...

She realized that she wanted, very desperately, for the card to have been Chloe's. She wanted proof of that.

Why? She wanted it to be true... not because she wanted Ryan to be cheating on her. She did not want that. She hadn't wanted that, not until now. But now she kind of... did?

So that she could justify her own desire for Jasper.

Jasper.

He was twenty-four years old. Her husband's boss.

She covered her face with her hands. God, she couldn't even stand thinking about herself, she was so... twisted. This was crazy. It was awful. She was an awful wife.

And yet? If Ryan had taken Chloe's key from her? Was she any worse than him?

She threw herself backward on the bed, tears leaking from her eyes.

She would have to tell Ryan.

She would have to.

Chapter Eight

"Hey. Hi. You're back. Hi."

She shifted uncomfortably under the covers and brought her hands to her hair to straighten it out. Ryan was looking at her strangely. Her fingers found dampness at her scalp, and a quick glance in a mirror told her that her face was flushed.

Ryan glanced at the TV. "You're watching TV?"

"Uh.. yeah, well, just to have some sound on. I mean, at first that's why. I was, uh, just waiting up for you."

This all sounded crazy. And that's because it was. She never watched TV, and she didn't put things on to "have some sound on." Ryan knew this and his face showed his confusion.

It only made her blush more. The last thing she wanted right now was for her husband to know what she'd been doing just now. No matter how this conversation went.

And that was because she had been masturbating. By itself, she figured it wouldn't be the end of the world if her husband found out. Embarrassing,

sure. He'd probably want to know why she hadn't just waited to have sex with him.

But with everything else going on? And all of it about to come out in one way or another? That would make it different.

That, and she had been thinking about Jasper. It had just sort of... happened. The TV was something she'd turned on to keep her brain distracted, quieted. It hadn't worked. She had no idea when she'd turned the sound down. It didn't matter: her thoughts returned to Jasper again and again, and this had been the result.

Twice. Since her return to the hotel room. Except this time, she hadn't finished yet.

"What were you watching?"

"Huh?"

Ryan's face was scrunched up, his eyes moving quickly around the room. Suspicion was growing behind his features. "On TV?" he said, almost impatiently, and then squinted. "You said you were watching TV." He pointed to the TV.

"Oh." She looked at the screen. The current images offered zero clues about what show was on, or even what channel she was watching. "Maybe a movie...I... I don't know. I was kind of dozing off."

Why was she lying? Why was she lying about *this*, of all the things she could be lying about? She could see Ryan was getting more and more confused by the second.

"That key you gave me didn't work," she blurted, when Ryan stepped closer and gave her an even stranger look while slipping his feet out of his shoes.

She watched his reaction. He frowned, looking at his feet as he took them out of the shoes. "Really?"

She decided to go on the offensive. She leaned to the side, seductively, and propped her head in her hand, leaning on one elbow. There was an element of raw sexuality to this: she was still horny, still so close to the edge of an orgasm.

Ryan seemed to pick up on this. Half his mouth turned up in interest. His attention went immediately to her breasts, which were tucked behind a silk sleep-shirt and spilling from the dainty collar. Her nipples were hard.

"You didn't have someone else's key card in your pocket by any chance?" she said. This came across as sultry. She wasn't sure how she had wanted to say it; now that she had said it like that, she wasn't sure where to go with it.

Ryan. He blinked, laughed a little - was it nervously? - and looked at his feet again. "Oh. That."

Oh, that?

"Was it Chloe's?" She was still using her seductive voice, smiling, twisting her hair a little. Ryan gave her a strange but hopeful smile when he looked back up at her.

"Chloe?... Wait.. huh?"

"She just seemed to be flirting with you a lot. I thought maybe..." She made a strange, flirtatious gesture. Ryan didn't seem to be paying much attention to her words. She lowered her chin and stared him down.

"No, nothing like that. But, uh, what did you do with it? Asking for a friend."

She stared at him, her mouth open. "What...?"

Ryan smiled back at her. There was a tense silence.

Should she tell him that she'd gone out to the pool deck to retrieve the card? That it had been scratched, and she'd been unable to think of Chloe's room number, and those were the only things stopping her from taking it upstairs to see if it was Chloe's card?

Did she tell him that most of her didn't want that to be the case... but a part of her, a small part of her, relished the idea of having an excuse to act out her fantasies with Jasper? At the very least, give her permission to keep "the kiss" a secret?

"Joke," Ryan said, when she didn't say anything. "It was a joke."

Relief started to fill her veins, tinged with regret... and then just as suddenly, it all evaporated as a single thought materialized in her head:

Ryan had used a card to open the door and get in, just now.

So *that* key card, the one he'd given her before all of this had happened, was not a key to this room.

She sat up. "How did you get into the room?"

"What?"

She pointed at him. "Now *you* look guilty."

As soon as she'd said that, she realized it was a mistake. By putting the emphasis on "you," she was implying that *she* had looked guilty before. And Ryan was not the kind of man not to notice this kind of rhetorical error.

"*I* look guilty, huh?" Ryan said, good-naturedly. He sat down on the end of the bed and started to take his socks off. "Sounds like *you* feel guilty about something."

"Sounds like projection." They were using joking tones, but this made Ryan look at her sideways and pause, his mouth open.

"O...kay," he said. He started to match his socks together, rolling them into each other.

Which definitely wasn't normal.

"What's going on, Vanessa?"

Her hands flew to her face and she covered it, shaking her head. A sudden urge to cry threatened to break through. "Oh my God," she said. She shook her head some more. "I actually can't believe it."

Ryan's hand on her arm. "Babe. I was *joking* about Chloe. I gave you my room key, remember? I got another one at reception."

She peered at him through her fingers. He shrugged, smiling. "I mean, Chloe did show me how to do that, so..."

When she didn't react to this with a laugh, he reassured her by putting his hand on her back. "Okay, jeez, this is serious. I'm sorry. I'll stop making jokes."

She dropped her hands. She was still shaking her head. "I have to tell you something," she blurted. Again, this came out without warning. She felt suddenly cold and sick. With the words of a confession on the tip of her tongue, she felt terrible.

Thank God. Thank God she was coughing this up now, before anything went any further. All of it - every sordid detail - now seemed so trashy and awful that she couldn't even imagine how bad she'd feel if she had done something more with Jasper. Having to confess to anything else would have been torture.

Ryan tossed the socks aside. He shifted his height, climbing closer to her. "You ran up a really huge bill at the bar?" he asked. "I know about that already." He moved his face closer to the crevice of her tits, going in with a hungry look.

"Jasper kissed me by the pool," she said quickly, pushing on his shoulder.

He sat back, stunned.

"I was out there because... I went that way to go get a key. A new key. That one didn't work. And he... oh God." She covered her face again. "I don't know what happened. I'm so sorry."

Ryan said nothing. She dropped her hands. "I really don't know how it..." she began, but didn't finish.

"Kissed you, kissed you?" Ryan asked.

The tone of his voice was strange. It wasn't as angry as she'd expected. She nodded.

"Jasper."

She just stared back at him.

"My boss."

He stood up, looking down at her with what should have been disdain, but wasn't quite meeting that expectation. His eyes went to the ceiling. A long sigh. "How... how did that happen, exactly?"

Her mouth opened. How, exactly? What was she supposed to say?

"Vanessa?"

"I don't..." Her mouth snapped shut. Tears welled up in her eyes. She looked up at him imploringly. Shook her head again. "I really... have no idea..."

Ryan became impatient, but again, the impatience had qualities that she hadn't expected. "Well, what were you doing?"

Her mouth would open, but her lips and her tongue would not form words.

"Sitting? Lying down? Standing? In the pool? Out of the pool?"

"Standing."

Ryan was turning now, arms crossed. "Standing. By the pool." He extended one hand from his elbow. As if to say: continue. His face was

twisted in disbelief. But still, there was an undercurrent of emotion that Vanessa couldn't quite put her finger on.

"I... yes. Standing. By the pool." She looked down at her fingers.

"So... you were... what? Walking? Jogging? And you just ran into his face? Or what?"

She shook her head. A fat tear fell from her left eye.

"What, then?"

She looked up at him, and then she looked away, trying to swipe her tears away without it being obvious. "It was just... uh, we started talking, and then... uh, he took me by... surprise."

Ryan had his lips together and was looking at the ceiling. "So this was when? Before or after you were locked out?"

"After - I just... I went that way, I soaked my feet in the hot tub, I wanted to see if I could get there some other way. To the pool. And then when I stood up... Jasper was there. Outside. Watching me."

Ryan looked at her with disbelief. And why wouldn't he? They'd been married for a long time. He knew when she wasn't telling the whole truth.

She didn't know what to do. How much detail to confess. While she thought about it, Ryan got impatient.

"So let me get this straight. You were soaking your feet in the hot tub. And Jasper was just standing there. Staring at you."

She looked at her hands again. "Yes."

"There's nothing more to the story than that?"

She fixated on a nail. Ryan would, of course, know that there was.

"I just have a hard time believing that Jasper Cooper took a whole bunch of time to stare at you soaking your feet in the hot tub. I mean... you're hot. That dress was hot. Your ass looks amazing in it. But this doesn't add up."

She sighed, clasping her hands together. Another tear fell out of her eye.

"Okay, maybe I was doing something."

Ryan arched his eyebrows. "Naked? Were you naked?"

"What? Are you kidding me?"

He shrugged, smiling a little. This was reassuring. "I don't know. You're the only other spouse here so far, besides some dude. No one else is staying here. Maybe you decided to... you know... live a little?"

He sat next to her again and his hands started moving up and down one calf. Sensually.

What was happening?

"I wasn't naked," she said quietly. "But, uh... I *was* doing something."

It was as if a number of lights went off in Ryan's head all at once. If he had been a cartoon, he would have had steam coming out of his ears. His eyes moved, with a lizard-like speed and comprehension sparkling in them like diamonds, from her hands to her face to her tits to her face again. The appearance of comprehension deepened in his features.

"Something like what you were doing just before I came in here?"

"Oh my God," she said, but it didn't sound like quite the forceful denial she had intended. Ryan took her right hand, at the very same time, and lifted it to his fingers.

She sank down, biting her lower lip. There wasn't any point in denying it. And to be honest, Ryan didn't look *mad* about it.

"*You* were masturbating in the hot tub - ?!"

"On the side of it," she said quickly. "Fully clothed." She made a face. "I thought I was alone."

"And then Jasper... watched you -?"

"I didn't know he was there," she said.

" - and then he just... kissed you?!" Ryan's eyebrows went up, and his mouth fell open. He blinked once, shaking his head to the right. "Whoa."

She stared at him for a moment, scrunched down into the covers. The sweat at the nape of her neck was making her cool now. Their fingers were still intertwined, and she played with the tip of his pointer finger, then moved her slender fingers to his wedding band, sliding it sensually up and down his finger shaft. Twisting it as she went. His eyes went to her fingers. He watched for a while. The look on his face was similar to a look he wore when he watched himself fucking her, or spread cum on her belly back in the day when they used the pullout method. It was a particular, peculiar form of obsession. She missed it, she realized. It had been a long time since she'd this look on his face.

"Did you like it?" he asked her.

For a second she thought he was asking about her reminiscence of old times. Her heart beat faster. When she realized he was talking about Jasper, she stammered a little. "I, uh... well it was really like, not what, not what I was - just - it isn't easy to, that wasn't what -"

"It seems like you liked it." The way Ryan said this turned the heat up in the room about fifty degrees. A flush rose to her face and across her shoulders. Between her legs, her already-soaked pussy came back to its gnawing, craving self, panging with a profound ache.

Ryan used his free hand to reach out and drop the spaghetti straps of her camisole, one by one. "Do you have any panties on?"

Unexpected. She nodded warily.

"Take them off."

She only stared at him for a moment. In her mind, she replayed what had just happened. Had she not just confessed to him that Jasper had kissed her?

Had she not just failed to say whether she liked it or not?

As she thought about this, though, her hands were moving as though from their own accord, and Ryan was giving her a look that sizzled right through her skin. Twisting currents of heat and cold roiled in her abdomen. Her pussy got wetter. She found her panties with her fingers, hands on either side of her hips, and she scooted them side to side as she pulled. When they were halfway to her knees, Ryan pulled the covers away.

He did it slowly at first, the duvet scraping sensually over her skin. Then he tossed the whole thing violently onto the floor. His eyes went to her pussy, and congealed like they had just done, with focus and intent. Like the old days.

It was hot. It sizzled through her whole body. His hand went to her slit and he slipped his pointer finger into the wet and sticky mess. She froze with her hands on her panties, the silky material stretched between her thighs.

His eyes went to her face. He probed into her gash, finding her clit with ease. He rubbed it gently, and her mouth popped open. She emitted a breathy gasp.

Moving his finger very slowly, in erratic rhythms that made her shudder but promised no relief, he began to question her. "So you masturbated at the pool?"

She nodded, and he rewarded her with a jiggle of her clit that made her mewl.

"Your pussy is really, really wet."

"I - oh! - I know..." she stammered.

"So that was it? That was hours ago."

She moved her head slowly side to side. She found herself smiling, because Ryan was not angry. And because he was making her so... so hot.

"So one more time in here?"

Her mouth fell open. He was pinching her clit now, and slipped two other fingers into her pussy. "Your pussy is so wet it almost feels like Jasper did more than kiss you. Maybe he fucked you?"

"No!"

Ryan smiled. His fingers were fucking her while his thumb played with her clit. She had dropped her arms to either side of herself. Her breath was getting shaky.

"Did you want him to?"

She grasped his arm, her mouth opening even more. She was getting so close...

He slowed his fucking, and she felt her pussy spasming around his fingers.

"Were you thinking about him when you were masturbating?"

A dangerous question. His fingers paused, his thumb stroking so slowly that all it delivered was a jolt of pleasure every few seconds, while her pussy squeezed and jerked against his embedded fingers. She wasn't able to control any of this. A pain low in her abdomen began to grow in force: she needed release. She dug her fingernails into his forearm.

"You were," Ryan said. But he didn't look angry. His thumb moved even more slowly.

"Ohhhhhh!" she cried out, tipping her head back. She grasped his arm with both hands, pleased with the wiry strength beneath her palms. "Please, Ryan... make me come, let me come..."

He curled his fingers upward and his brief contact with her g-spot made one thigh jerk. She doubled over, unable to stop herself from feeling pained. "Ryan, Ryan... please..."

When she met his eyes he was fully engulfed in that look of obsession, which only made her hungrier for release. Her fingernails dig in deeper. Ryan became more obstinate, shifting his fingers slowly inside her, his thumb pressed to her clit. He squeezed her as though he wished to pick her up by her cunt. "I will," he said solemnly. A faint smile. "But I want you to say it."

She mewled some more and tried to twist away. It was futile. She opened her mouth with her head tipped back, and Ryan shook his head, using his other hand to tip her chin downward. "Look at me while you say it."

Her eyes went to his cock. He was still dressed, but the physical evidence was obvious: he was hard as a rock and it was changing the shape of his suit pants.

He followed her gaze. "You want that?"

She nodded. Holy fuck, did she ever. And she wanted *Ryan's* cock. In that moment, however strange it seemed, the cock she was craving was not Jasper's, even if it was Jasper's cock that had led to this moment.

Ryan shifted, fingers in deeper. "Then say it. Tell me how you thought about him."

A demanding curl of his fingers. He pulled hard on the panties while he shifted onto the bed, his hand still shoved in her pussy. He straddled her at the shins. The panties were pulled to her calves. He grasped her right leg and pushed it up, so that her knee bent and her foot slipped out of the panty leg. "Say it."

"Ryan..."

His fingers went in deeper. "Do you want me to fuck you?"

She felt her head nodding, her mouth open. His left hand was gripping her thigh now, pushing it back into the mound of pillows beneath her lower back.

"Then say it."

"I was thinking about Jasper when I was in the hot tub."

Ryan smiled. His thumb stroked her clit. And then stopped.

"And I... I hiked my dress up, and went like this..." She showed him how she'd slid her hand in the crease of her thigh and reached with her fingers to masturbate discreetly. When her fingers got to her own pulpy mess of a pussy, Ryan lifted his arm to push her fingers away with the back of his wrist.

"And what did you think about?"

She was confused. "About... him -"

"What was he doing to you?"

"Eating my pussy."

Ryan seemed almost triumphant in his nod. Almost like he was proud of her. He made a questioning smile of his lips. "And? Was it any good?"

"I - I mean - yes..."

Suddenly he rose up on his knees, half-standing. His fingers left her pussy, and they ended up in his mouth as she howled with displeasure. It was short-lived, though: Ryan was licking her pussy juices from his fingers and seemed to like the taste. It reminded her of the way Jasper ate that food at that first party. Of how he...

"He licked my fingers off," she said.

The pulse of Ryan's cock was unmistakable. He froze with his fingers between his lips, just for a second, considering this information. A smile,

then he licked his fingertips clean one final time. "He did, did he?"

His other hand was at his belt, already pulling it out dramatically. A shiver of excitement and a dirty thought ran through her head: even if they had never played that game, it was sexually arousing thinking for a brief second that he was going to smack her ass for this indiscretion. But no. He was using both hands now that the belt was gone to get his cock out. It sprang loose, fully erect. The dull light of the room still managed to illuminate the shimmer of precum that had gathered at the tip and been smeared by his clothes.

"Did you imagine sucking his cock?"

Not that time. Not by the pool. But she had, alone in the room. She shook her head. "Not 'til I got back here," she said.

"Mm-hmm. And how would you do that? You think?"

It wasn't what she had imagined, at all. But she was inspired by something else. She was smiling, her pussy throbbing and wet, as she slid down the bed further, letting her hands trail up to above her ears. She pulled herself between his legs by her heels, digging into the mattress to drag her body until she was lying on the bed with her face just in front of his cock and below it.

Ryan made a noise. It was like "uh-huh," but more questioning. More surprised. He guided his cock, pointing it down toward her. She had to push up on her arms a little to lift her head, and she strained with her tongue to lap at his balls and the underside of his cock. He guided the tip to her lips and she enclosed it, swirling her tongue around the crown.

The briny taste of his cum slipped into the crevices of her mouth, bitter and so salty it made her eyes sting. His cock pulsed between her teeth. She

felt a pearl of pre-cum trickle to the flat of her tongue and then disperse into the corners and cracks of her teeth.

She wanted it all in her mouth. Was this because she wanted Ryan, or Jasper? She didn't know. Sucking cock wasn't even her favorite thing - it was mostly a chore. At least it had been for a long time. But now she had an ache at the back of her throat, a desire to feel that salty brine trickling against the very back of her throat, her stomach squirming with a suppressed gag reflex, her nostrils flaring to suck in more air.

Ryan seemed to read her mind. His hand went to her hair and his fingers at the back of her head, supporting her. She propped herself on one arm and seized his cock with the other hand. Then, with Ryan's help, she moved her head to suck her husband's dick all the way to the back of her throat. When her lips met the wiry curls of his pubic hair, she was satisfied. Her eyelids dropped, and she let herself think for a moment about Jasper's cock instead -

She began to suck rhythmically on Ryan, both reality and fantasy in her head at exactly the same time. She forgot to breathe until the pain of her lungs reminded her abruptly. She withdrew, gasping for air. The scent of spit and cum rose in her nostrils, saliva dangled from her lips to Ryan's cock. She dove in again, and enclosed the top three inches of his dick, ready to go all the way again. She could feel the pulse of his blood against her tongue, the tense veins as bumps on the throbbing mass, taste his precum -

"Oh. God. Baby, I'm gonna come..." Ryan tilted his hips away from her and let go of her head. He remained there, heaving, concentrating, his cock bobbing in the air. She smiled at him. Then she pushed herself up, rising from between his legs to the head of the bed again.

He moved down, simultaneously. She folded her legs to her knees and then shot them out so they were on either side of his thighs. He shoved the pants down to his knees.

"Are you going to think about Jasper while I fuck you full of come?"

She stared at him, smiling. There was no way he could win at this game. His cock was twitching and bobbing like it was on the high seas. She smiled. "Do you want me to?"

But he did. He waited, shaking with arousal.

She spread her legs. "Make me come. And then I'll tell you whatever you want."

Leaning over her. Hand on his cock, slipping it between her soaked labia. The head of it moving over her clit, him stroking her with his cock. Panting - it was her own breath, squeaking, whimpering. Heat covering her face, so much pussy juice that she could hear each stroke of the crown of his cock on her clit. Panic rising in her voice. Ryan's body shaking as he held himself over her.

"Say it."

"I'm thinking about Jasper fucking me," she said, her eyelids falling closed. "I'm thinking... about...it..."

The full, hard meat of his cock inside her suddenly. Her own voice: "His cock is so big..."

Slamming. The sound of the headboard banging. Heat between her legs bursting, a woman screaming. A pillow in her mouth. Her thighs shaking. A deep thrust, and then a pussy full of hot cum.

Shivers, racing up from her lower body and making her tremble violently as Ryan's weight sank onto her. His shirt was still on, and it was soaked through.

Vanessa lay in the darkness with her husband's weight on top of her. Ryan seemed sleepy, she was sleepy. There was a lot to talk about between them, and she knew that. She felt disoriented by what had just happened, but sleep was claiming her. She barely noticed when Ryan slid off to the side and settled next to her, and she was sliding into sleep when she heard him say - or rather, murmur so sleepily she would later not be entirely sure she'd even heard it:

"Maybe you should sleep with him... get me... that promotion..." And then, some time later: "Finally."

Chapter Nine

The next morning, they woke up a little late, considering all the planned activities. They didn't have much time to talk, and if Vanessa was being honest, she was grateful for that. She knew they *should*, but something about actually doing that made her afraid that the excitement of what had happened would evaporate.

Ryan was in an excellent mood. He rolled over to kiss her (before they knew how late it was) and told her what a great night it had been. He was on top of her, his cock hard, and interest gleaming in his eyes. There was nothing super-weird about that: Ryan had always loved having sex in the morning. Later in their marriage, that had become the more common time, because they were always both so tired at the end of the day.

His level of enthusiasm, however, *was* new.

"That was hot last night," he said. And they were about to go at it, so Vanessa took this as a serious sentiment. They heard someone thump on the door right then, as they passed by in the corridor. This shook Ryan a little bit (though not entirely), but Vanessa reached out and swept up her phone. It was very bright out. She had the feeling they were late.

And she was correct. "Oh my God!" she said. "It's 8:30!"

Ryan was due at an activity at 9:00 *sharp*, as the email (written by Chloe) had suggested. If there was one thing Vanessa had come to understand about the culture at Nimbus, it was that being late for activities was a big no-no.

Ryan laughed, but he pushed off of her and strolled to the bathroom. "That's too bad," he said, grinning before entering. He had an erection, Vanessa noticed, and it lasted all the way into the bathroom.

This turned her on. It turned her on in ways that she couldn't really account for, because they were so far outside of her experience or anything she'd ever really considered. The standard trope she supposed she'd always "believed" was that if she stepped out of line with another man, her husband would be furious - not turned on, as Ryan seemed to be.

She found her own arousal to be curious and foreign to herself. Was it Jasper or Ryan making her horny this morning? It was Ryan's erection - the sight of Ryan's erection, in fact - that made her slide down into the bed and slip her fingers into her pussy with the plan of masturbating. But Ryan's erection seemed to be the result of Jasper's behavior toward her, and Jasper was on her mind as well.

And then there was that thing Ryan had said last night - a thing she really needed to talk to him about. A thing she was actually, kind of, interested in being real.

Her eyes flew open: was she seriously thinking that?

"Babe," Ryan said, leaving the bathroom after just a few minutes. He had a toothbrush in his mouth and was peeling away the shirt he'd fallen asleep in. "I gotta go now, I need some coffee and some food."

She stared at him. Her hand was still between her legs, under the covers, discreet enough for him not to notice. "You're not taking a shower?" she asked. The question sounded silly. Ryan held a shirt up and then set it down and scrubbed his teeth a few times. He tossed the shirt over his shoulder, took the toothbrush from his mouth, and crawled onto the bed to kiss her. He tasted like mint. His skin smelled like sex.

"No time," he told her. She stuck out her lower lip - she wasn't even sure what that was supposed to mean. "Come down to breakfast with me, you can just come back afterward and do whatever you want with your day."

She needed a shower. "I need a shower," she said. Her pussy juices and cum had dried between her thighs, she smelled like sex beneath the covers. New arousal was going to intensify that situation.

"Just pop down. Have a coffee." Ryan was disappearing into the bathroom. He had the air of a man who had just had very satisfying sex. Which was... strange. But alluring. Vanessa had flashes of fantasy thoughts: what if she really did go all the way with Jasper? Was that something Ryan would be this happy about? But that couldn't be. She wouldn't be thrilled like this if Ryan had come back to tell her that Chloe had kissed him.

"I really need a shower," she said. "I smell like sex." He needed a shower, too.

Ryan popped his head out. "I know," he said, with a grin. The toothbrush was back in his mouth. She heard him spit into the sink after disappearing back into the bathroom. "I like it," he called.

She threw the covers off. Huh. Well, if that was what her husband wanted, she really could use a coffee. She supposed if he just put on her workout clothes...

A smile crept onto her face. She'd bought a new workout outfit that looked as good on her as the swimsuit. Her smile faded: what would be the point? And she didn't have time to make herself look all that great... what if Jasper was there?

As if he had read her mind, Ryan passed through, buttoning up the shirt. "Jasper might be there," he said. He smiled at her as he tugged his collar into place.

She didn't know how to respond to that so she smiled blandly and went into the bathroom.

"I'm leaving in five," Ryan called out. So she hurried up, peeing and then - in an act that she had only seen in TV shows or movies and never even done herself in her whole lifetime - she used a damp washcloth to clean between her legs. She threw it deliberately on the floor so no mishaps occurred, and looked at herself in the mirror.

If she was being honest, she looked pretty damn good. With a few strokes of concealer and a beauty balm rubbed in quickly on her skin, she looked as fresh as a daisy. She put her hair in a ponytail and gave herself one last look.

Who are you getting ready for?

The question came to her in her own voice, as distinctly as if she'd said it inside her own head.

A moment of chilling quiet as she looked at her own eyes in the mirror and urged herself to answer.

Was it possible the answer was both?

Jasper Cooper was some kind of bold, she had to hand him that.

Ryan had gone ahead of her to breakfast, so she had donned her gym outfit with a little more care and then headed to the dining room behind him. It was no surprise to her to find Chloe seated next to Ryan at a table. She was talking so animatedly that her red curls were bobbing all over the place.

A flash of irritation went through Vanessa, but it wasn't nearly the same as the previous times she'd seen Chloe interacting with her husband. She calmly went up to the buffet set out, and as she passed through Ryan's field of vision, his eyes went to her. She was satisfied - supremely so - by the fact that she took Ryan's eyes right off Chloe and that he followed her, Vanessa, with a look of interest as she made her way to the buffet. He grinned, she was grinning. It was fun. It was exciting. It was like they were the ones carrying on an affair.

She was pondering that, and all of its confusing implications, when she felt Jasper's presence behind her. This feeling was more like one of schoolgirl crush, but even that description didn't really capture it. Her skin felt like it had been set aflame, shivers traveled all over her back, and she felt a little queasy in her stomach. But at the same time, there was a purely physical element to it: her mind went immediately and only to sex. And even more curiously, to her husband's erect cock this morning, then on to the possibilities of Jasper's.

She selected a coffee mug. Jasper stood next to her, and she acknowledged his presence without looking at him. She smiled, but she was already smiling, so this wasn't much of a difference or a signal. She felt her hips move a little. "Good morning," she said.

Jasper moved in closer, until his shoulder just brushed hers. As if there was a really long, pushy line next to him, and he was getting jostled toward

her. But there wasn't. She stiffened, and fought the urge to look over her shoulder or behind them.

This by itself was bold: he was too close for this to be just an ordinary interaction. There were twenty people in the dining room, and any one of them could have seen this. In fact, the way Nimbus employees followed Jasper around like little doggies, there was almost no chance they weren't seeing it.

"Let me," Jasper said. His hand moved to the cup. She froze. This was all happening out of plain sight, but it was still crazy: he slipped his fingers over her hand and used his pointer finger to draw a slow, sensual circle on the back of it. This languid stroke traveled through her body like wildfire and she was left with an internal shakiness and an arousal so strong that Jasper might as well have touched her like that on the face of her clitoris.

What was wrong with her?

He had his hand around much of the cup and when she turned to look at him, he pulled on it gently, causing her to look down at the cup. Only then did she understand that he wanted to take it from her: but his finger was still stroking the back of her hand.

She relinquished the cup and Jasper took it but didn't move. She pictured the entire dining room behind them, all the forks dropping and a collective gasp coming from the employees. This didn't happen, but she was sure the sentiment was there - if she looked behind herself she'd the venomous eyes of onlookers, green with envy and accusatory. Adulteress, slut... and what about Ryan? Getting cuckolded right there in the open?

"You have a flush today," Jasper said. She had turned to look at him, and she wanted to be angry or tell him to shut up, but she didn't. A very real

flush took to her cheeks. She could feel it spread over her cheekbones. Heat gathered at her neck.

"You must have gotten a good night's sleep," Jasper said.

She turned her attention back to the food at the table. It all looked so whole-grained or gluten-free and vegan that she wanted to slap someone. Jasper went around her and started to pour some coffee into her cup. Without asking her, with her mouth partly open to tell him to put cream in it, he started to pour that in, too. He grinned smugly, sensing her reaction: how did he know that's what she wanted.

Tapping a sugar packet with his fingers. "I know everything about people who interest me," he said, as if she'd asked aloud. It was so close to what she wanted to know that she couldn't help letting her mouth fall open again.

"Did you have sex this morning?" Jasper asked next, as if he was asking only about how well she'd slept.

"That's none of your -" she began, but cut herself off. Jasper looked at her, amused, holding the coffee mug as if he intended to drink it himself.

"I can smell it on you," he said. She made herself pull her mouth up and take the cup from his hands.

He leaned forward. "Was it good?"

"Oh my God," she said, turning back to the pastries. She set the cup down so he wouldn't see it shaking.

Jasper nodded, grinning, taking another cup easily from where they were piled, putting his arm in front of her. He was in a casual long-sleeved t-shirt and his muscles could be seen in the contours of the material. "It was," he said, another little grin fleeting across his lips. "Were you thinking of me?"

Her hands stopped. She froze. A hundred possible actions exploded into her thoughts like a confetti bomb, complete with a poof! sound in her mind.

Her mouth opened, no sound came out. She wanted desperately to turn around and look at Ryan for guidance, or just to gauge how he was taking this.

"Maybe," she heard herself say, noncommittally. She swept her eyes across the table and was even more surprised when she heard her own voice, sultry and tempting, continue, a wry smile on her lips. Oh God, did she just turn toward him? Was she seriously batting her eyelashes? Was this seriously her, saying to her husband's 24-year-old boss: "I didn't have that much to go on, though."

Power, like electricity, surged from her lower abdomen and outward to her limbs. She had turned slightly, and Jasper was now pouring himself a cup of coffee, lips pressed together, nodding, smiling. She could see the dining room in her peripheral vision, see that Ryan was indeed watching her, and that plenty of people were. Sure, she and Jasper were three feet apart now, and Jasper was bringing his coffee to his lips, grinning. There was nothing inappropriate in their body language, or even their expressions. Provided that no one knew what had gone on between them. Or noticed his fingers on her hand earlier, which would have been impossible to see.

But people know things are simmering between two people even when they don't see the signs so clearly as all that. Mingled with her sense of power - she now commanded both Ryan's and Jasper's attention fully, sexually, powerfully - was a feeling of shame. This was ludicrous. Dangerous. She was a bad wife. This guy was twenty-four years old.

Jasper sipped his coffee, looking over the rim at her, eyes burning through her core. "We'll have to do something about that."

And then he left.

She stacked some bread products, chosen indiscriminately, onto a plate and picked up her things to take them to the table.

"Everybody, we start in five," Jasper said, on his way out the door.

Chairs scraped and everyone jumped up to get going as soon as Jasper was out of the doorway to the corridor to the other wing of the hotel. She was at the table, setting her plate down. Chloe was standing up. "Wow," she said, in a faux-sweet tone. "That's a lot of carbs." This was girl-bitchiness, through and through.

Vanessa sat down and picked up a croissant, the sort of thing she really couldn't afford to eat anymore. She bit into it while looking at Chloe. Ryan was still seated, smiling at his wife.

"I exercise a lot," Vanessa told Chloe, through buttery flakes. Then she glanced at Ryan, who smiled and nodded to himself. Chloe was flustered by this but admirably continued, punching Ryan playfully on the shoulder in the kind of way that seemed to imply more than just "friendliness."

"Okay, well, see ya," Chloe said. A dangerous look that Vanessa met with equanimity. Ryan stood up, his abdomen moving with a chuckle.

"I gotta run," he told her. A look over his shoulder. "What did Jasper say?" he whispered.

Did she dare? Was this real? What *had* Jasper said? She couldn't even think of how to summarize it. She set her croissant down and smiled, leaning toward Ryan's side of the table. But then she couldn't think of what to say, or a single phrase Jasper had uttered. It was more of a vibe, she wanted to explain. A raw, animalist vibe. He wanted to fuck her, that was what he'd really been saying.

A hand clapped on Ryan's shoulder. "Come on old man, don't make the boss mad," a colleague, far younger than Ryan, said jokingly.

Ryan's eyes were locked on Vanessa's.

"I'll tell you later," she mouthed.

Ryan mimed groaning theatrically, and moved along with his colleagues, not taking his eyes off her until it was critical to do so in order to avoid falling on his face, which he almost did.

Vanessa settled back in her chair, feeling regal and commanding in her tight white track suit over her very, very sexy teal blue workout outfit. The pants and sweatshirt were made of a thin white material that was not exactly see-through, but which fit so snugly and were transparent enough to show the contours of her short shorts and her sports bra very clearly through them.

Everyone who passed her gave her at least a little look, to which they received her cool, confident, smiling, very direct look back.

Then she ate everything she'd brought over by herself in the dining room, thinking about sex with one of two men, rotating them through her fantasies.

Then she laughed.

This was not real life.

But it was fun.

Chapter Ten

She decided to take her mind off everything by going for a horseback ride. The Nimbus people would be doing their own activities all morning - things she couldn't really join in on - and if she stayed in the room, she was going to explode. She felt dangerously out of control, and she didn't really know if what Ryan had said to her before falling asleep was just a drunken, sleepy, half-dream murmuring or something real. She'd had no time to talk to him.

Also, was she kidding herself? This whole thing was preposterous. Nothing like this ever ended well, not even in the movies - at least the ones that were percolating to the forefront of her mind (*Unfaithful*, *Adore*, *Babygirl*).

Still.

"Jesus," she muttered, as she approached the stables, to where she'd been directed by the receptionist (who, thankfully, was not the one from the night before.) She needed to get a grip. And if she couldn't do that, she needed to at least get Jasper off her mind until she talked to her husband. What she did

not need to do was engage in all these fantasies of having her cake and eating it too, because that kind of thing *didn't even happen in the movies*.

None of these thoughts made Jasper's lean muscled torso that she imagined in detail, or the imagined images of his cock, disappear from her mind. She reminded herself of how young he was. That he was her husband's boss. That danger lurked everywhere.

Mostly, that just made it more appealing.

"I can't let you go out alone," the stable-hand said, after she made her request in a daze. "Why don't you just wait until the group is going out?"

He was a man in his thirties, she adjudged. She sighed. She watched his eyes as they moved over her body in quick movements that he clearly couldn't control. This was the kind of thing she'd noticed happening more often to her now that she was in her forties. She never acted on it though.

Her body felt like it was someone else's as she jutted a hip out seductively. Knee-high boots, tight jeans, a mock sleeveless turtleneck and a jean jacket. She had thrown that on hastily when she stepped into the cool shadows of the stable area, looking for the guide. She let the jean jacket slip from her right shoulder as she leaned against the wooden counter between them and tossed her hair over her shoulder.

His eyes went right to her bare skin. He smiled nervously. The same thrilling juice was squeezed out of this interaction as what she'd felt earlier at the buffet: how had she never tapped into this energy before? Why had she always resisted it? It was practically child's play, drawing men's attention in this way.

Not that this stable-hand was her bag. His eyes went nervously back to her face. Lingered at her lips, darted away. He gave a nervous laugh and a shrug. "I'm sorry."

"Hmmm," she said, tapping her fingers fan-like over the counter. "It's so weird, is all, because they told me I could do this."

Another nervous smile. "They, uh... well, I don't... who told you?"

"Nimbus," she said. And then had a second, dangerous thought. "Mr. Cooper himself, actually."

The words were already out of her mouth. They'd already had their intended effect - making the stable-hand nervous and fluttery - before she realized fully what she'd done. Cool, thrilling arousal snaked through her abdomen.

"I..." He looked around, as if someone would come to help him. She anticipated him leaning forward, whispering: "I guess I can do it for you, just this once." She could tell he very much wanted to. She shifted so that her breasts were more prominent, so the best side of her face was toward him. Gave him a pretty and hopeful smile.

He shook his head. "I don't know..."

She pouted. This worked on him as well, because it made him grimace helplessly. She was paying so much attention to this that her body acted like a separate thing, she could feel her fingers slipping into her pocket, pulling out her phone. She could feel the haughty expression on her face as she started to look up the email, planning to show it to him... that was all she had intended.

She could have sworn.

But her mouth was saying, as her fingers moved over the phone and she twisted her lips into a pretty pout:

"Mr. Cooper is the one who told me this wouldn't be a problem," she heard herself saying. "I'm sure it's what he was expecting."

A sigh. Some tapping on the computer. A phone call to the front desk or a manager while he held up a finger and gave her a hopeful look.

She scrolled her phone. She didn't have Jasper's number, and she was grateful for that. She didn't even know what the hell she was doing. This wasn't her. She didn't flirt with people to get her way. Her thoughts were all over the place as she pretended to be searching for... what? She needed to just go back to the pool.

"Tell you what," she began.

He held up his finger again. "Oh, great," he said. Covered the speaker. "He was walking right by," he whispered loudly.

She froze, a smile plastered to her face.

"Yes. Okay." He looked at her, covered the mouthpiece again. "What's your name?"

In another time, long ago - as far back as last week - she would have been nervous and felt bad as she answered this. Heck, she wouldn't have pressed the issue. But she tossed her hair, and it gave her a very specific but unable thrill that congealed as arousal again to say, imperiously:

"Of course. I'm Vanessa Cole."

As if he wouldn't have known that.

A smile. He repeated her name into the phone. "Okay," he said, and cradled it carefully. A big grin. "He said he's coming right up."

"Oh that's not -" she began, planning to say "necessary."

And yet...

She smiled.

Regrouped.

Fluffed her hair and dropped her big glasses onto her nose. "Perfect," she said. "I'll wait outside. Do you mind if I pet the horses in that enclosure?"

She had her hand on a black horse, one who nuzzled her hand aggressively at first but was now under her control, impatient, maybe wanting to ride. This was the one she wanted, and she wanted it in a sexual way. Not the horse, per se: the act of getting the horse for the ride after what she'd just done.

Sure, she reminded herself of the bad movies, and that she hadn't actually spoken to Ryan. She reminded herself that her phone was within her reach, that she could send a text to Ryan. But what was she doing, really? She just wanted to mount this horse and go on a ride by herself. That was all. *Literally* mount a horse.

The sound of one of the fancy covered ATVs they used to get around the ranch. She glanced over her shoulder. Jasper was climbing out. She turned her attention back to the horse.

He came to stand next to her. His hands were in his pockets.

"How badly do you want to ride this horse?" he asked, smiling, looking out into the enclosure as he reached a hand to the animal. She stared as the horse responded to Jasper, better than he had to her. Jasper's hands were erotic to her as they ran over his muzzle: obviously, he knew what he was doing with his fingers.

A tightness in her chest. He wasn't really - not really - saying what she thought he was.

She turned to him. "A lot," she said simply.

"Do you know *how*?" His face was serious. His eyes glittering with interest.

"I wouldn't be asking, if I didn't."

They were fencing. Jasper smiled, only barely. "This is a very expensive horse, they tell me. I'd have to pay for it if anything happened."

"I have it on good authority that you're very wealthy."

Jasper stared at her, intrigued, a smile lifting his lips, his eyes narrowing. "Mmm. Because I calculate risk versus reward very carefully."

They were so close to a precipitous cliff now that she almost felt like she'd already gone over. If this was a game before this moment, it all seemed very real now.

"It's not very risky letting me ride this horse," she said, turning back to the horse, who nuzzled her hand. "I know what I'm doing."

A pause. Jasper moving closer. As the heat built between them, the horse began to paw lightly at the ground. She felt queasiness overturn with arousal in her belly. Jasper's eyes went up and down her body again. "Do you," he said, in his statement-as-question style. "But what's in it for me?"

She laughed. It was partly nerves. Partly, it was also the cheapness of his offer: the empowerment she'd felt earlier in the day was superior to this token. Did he really think she'd sell herself for a horse ride?

"I'm not going to cheat on my husband for a horse ride," she told him, her voice very quiet and suddenly serious. She smiled, but even she could tell that she had crossed a line, not only outside of herself but within as well.

She wouldn't cheat on her husband for a horse ride, it implied. But that didn't mean she wouldn't do it for something else.

Jasper was genuinely amused by this. And in disbelief. When she turned to look at him, she felt suddenly taller, more in control of the interactions than she ever had before. She saw this confidence register in his eyes and a new kind of interest spark. A competitive dimension seemed to appear out

of nowhere between them: before, he had been a hunter and she had been prey. Now he wasn't quite as assured about what was going on.

She liked that. She let her pleasure show and turned back to the horse, scratching its long nose.

"No, I suppose you wouldn't," Jasper said.

A pause. A rippling, tense, glorious moment of uncertainty. She felt like she was flying.

"So what *would* you cheat on your husband for?" Jasper asked.

He was looking at her point-blank. His hand went to her left hand as he moved closer, holding her in his gaze, locked on her, trying to overpower her, getting closer to his goal.

She had taken the game too far, she sensed. There was no way out except to either laugh and end it all, or to take it to the next level. That much she could see. Jasper's fingers traced over the back of her hand, and she was frozen there, hearing only her own breath. Now they brushed her thigh. She had to do something, say something...

It was prompted, right there in the queue, and Ryan was the one who had put the idea there, in her mind, ready to be plucked out of thin air.

"Maybe if my husband got something out of it," she said. As casually as breathing. Attention back to the horse, her mind flying and careening wildly: this was wrong, what was she doing? "Something tangible. Then I wouldn't feel guilty."

"A promotion."

He said it, not her.

But now it was out there. If she was going to stop this game, now was the time. She could see that as she turned back to him. Her chest was pounding.

"Something like that."

Calculations were happening in Jasper's head. She could see it. A new estimation of her was forming, and dangerously, he liked her more: she could see that in the way his lip curled and the dark, competitive edges of his personality took shape somehow in his features.

"Have you done this before?"

God. Of course not. But did he need to know that? She shrugged.

"You surprise me, Mrs. Cole."

She said nothing. Inside, full panic was taking hold in a few places: behind her sternum, where it was tight. At the nape of her neck, where it was sweaty. Between her legs, her pussy ached and she was getting wet.

He was closer still. The stable-hand came out and her eyes shifted to him. Jasper let a beat go by, his hand lifted to run the back of it along her body, over her right breast where her nipple popped to life at his touch. A grin. He stepped back. "I'll get you your horse," he said.

"How nice."

"I suppose you want payment beforehand. Regarding the other matter."

The allusion to the time-honored practice of whores throughout history getting payment before services rendered was glaring. In another time of her life - again, probably just weeks ago - this would have made her scoff, or feel repulsive. It poured right over her now, cascading down her shoulders and making a chill travel up her spine, her nipples harden, her sexual energy coil tightly, ready to spring. Another flurry of fantasies danced wildly in her head, most of them full of cock and sex. She was intensely aware of her eyelids as they closed for the last time on the chapters of her life when she was not, and could never even imagine being, a whore.

The concentration remained as her eyelids opened. Her lips puckered into a wry smile. "Naturally," she said.

Jasper turned. His smile was unmistakable. Something inside her screamed: this was basically a verbal contract.

There was no backing out now, she had gone too far. A pit opened up in her abdomen and for a second she was in free-fall.

But very suddenly, the sensation evaporated and she felt high again. Mostly, calm reigned inside her. And heat. If there was shame, she couldn't bring it to the forefront of her mind.

"I want you to let her ride the horse," Jasper was saying, strolling into the stables. His voice trailed off and the stable hand followed him, his eyes shifting one last time to Vanessa. In them she saw that he recognized her for exactly what she was - if not yet, if not exactly, but in spirit at the very least, and likely soon to actually be: a mistress.

She sent a text to Ryan from way out in the flat areas just before a grove of Aspen trees.

I need to talk to you. I think I've done something terrible.

She'd resigned herself to confessing to Ryan, and then deferring to whatever he said. God, what if he had been joking? What if he had never said anything at all? She felt like the whole world was spinning wildly out of control. Deep down inside she could feel - almost like strings attached to

her insides that were being handled by a puppeteer somewhere else - that she was praying Ryan would say yes.

Yes to what? In some ways, she rode along feeling like none of this could possibly be happening. She managed to convince herself that this was all just a game that would evaporate soon enough, which was too bad, but she was being silly. Jasper Cooper could have any woman he wanted, and he wasn't going to do something so... blatantly unethical just to sleep with a woman twenty years older than him.

Was he?

Was she?

The message was not delivered until that afternoon, probably because of the distance from the nearest router - they were, after all, in the middle of nowhere. Had she intended for that to be the case? She would never know.

All she knew was that when she returned, Ryan's message was there. She didn't know if he had seen hers before or after she'd sent it. She stared at the words. Another message was there as well. The combination of the ideas made her wildly dizzy.

From Ryan:

You are not going to believe my news.

From the unknown number that was Jasper's, beneath a flurry of texts that she glanced at in confusion – she hadn't seen them before, though the sight of them now jogged her memory. Jasper had mentioned trying to text her the night before, and in all of the night's adventures, it had slipped her mind. But how had she missed them?

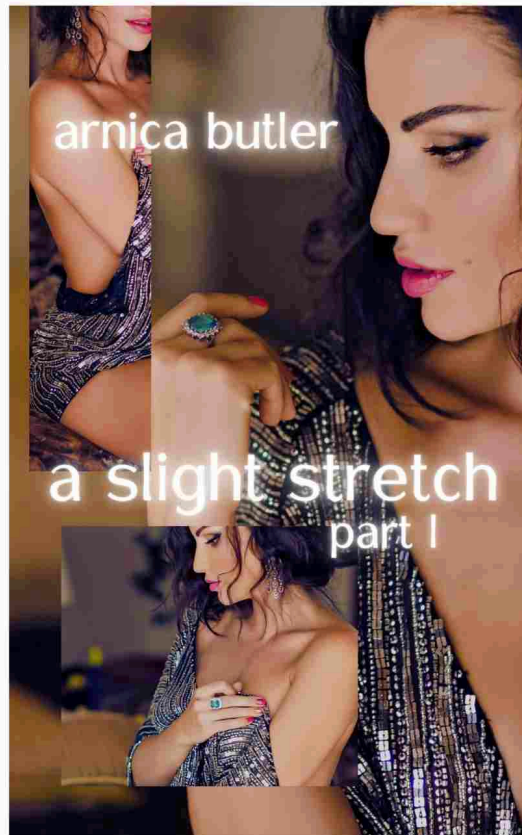
Words, phrases, snippets: they swarmed on the screen as her eyes tried to anchor to anything at all but the last message. She absorbed them in a few seconds – *your body, alone, take what I want...* but they never really reached her conscious thoughts for her to make sense of them.

Because the final message from that number stopped her heart, and her thoughts, cold:

Payment issued.

Also by

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and more. Complete catalog available at her Amazon Author Page.*

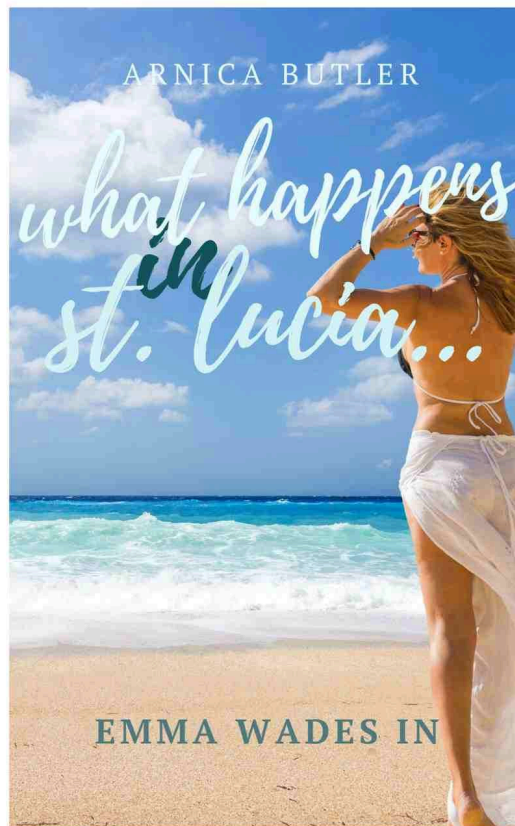


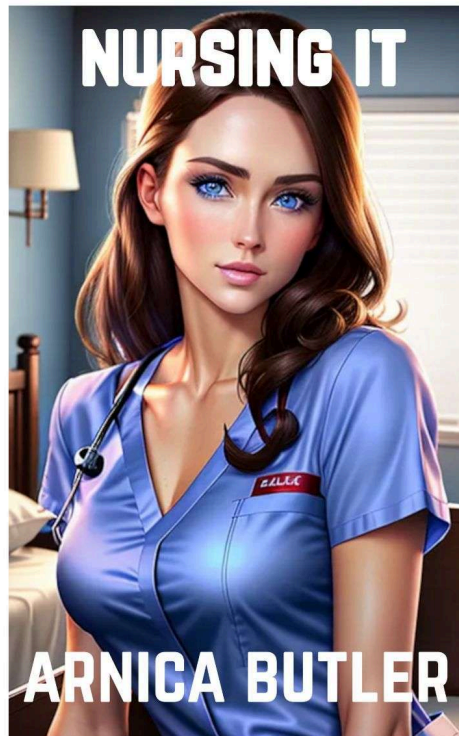
A mature woman with a successful business.
A husband who enjoys watching her with other
men. Younger men.
It's all fun and games for her...
Until she meets a man with an indecent
proposal.. and he whets her appetite for
something darker.

Right at the start, their vacation takes some twists and turns. Their friend's son isn't the boy they used to know.

He's in the prime of his life, and he isn't shy about letting Emma know that he doesn't see her as just a family friend.

Five people, a lot of social taboos, and two weeks with many possibilities.





Newly minted nurse and perky, pretty wife Chelsie
lands her first home-care gig.

Her patient is a well-endowed man whose needs
are pretty simple: he can't use his bandaged hands.

It would be so, so unprofessional, and so, so wrong.
Or would it?